

Mobilizing Magic: Occultism in Central Asia and the Continuity of High Persianate Culture under Russian Rule

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Introduction

Sometime between 1881 and 1885, the scholar Mullā Sayyid Maḥmūd Kh^wāja wrote a letter to Amir Muẓaffar (r. 1860-85), Manghit ruler of Bukhara, chiding him for his weakness in the face of Russian occupation and proposing a revitalization of science as the solution—the occult science of *jafr*.¹ This science,

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1 This document is preserved in the State Archive of Uzbekistan (Tsentrāl'nyi Gusudarstvennyi Arkhiv Respubliki Uzbekistana: henceforth TsGARUz), F i-126 ("Qushbegi Fond") O 1 D 1978, f. 20. The term *jafr* (lit., 'calfskin') properly designates the science of letter divination, particularly as associated with both 'Alī b. Abī Ṭālib and the detached sura-initial letters of the Qur'ān (*muqatta'āt*), held to contain within them all knowledge of past, present and future to the end of time. From the 16th century onward, however, *jafr* was in the Persianate world increasingly used metonymically to refer to the kabbalistic science of letters (*'ilm-i ḥurūf*), or lettrism, as a whole, as is the case here—Maḥmūd Kh^wāja clearly has in mind letter or talismanic magic, not prognostication. The standard Arabic term for the occult sciences more generally, including astrology (*aḥkām-i nujūm*), alchemy (*kīmīyā*) and a variety of magical and divinatory techniques, is *'ulūm gharība*, meaning those sciences that are unusual, rare or difficult, i.e., elite; less frequently used terms are *'ulūm khafīyya* and *'ulūm ghāmiḍa*, sciences that are hidden or occult. These terms are routinely used in classifications of the sciences, biographical dictionaries, chronicles, etc. Its 19th-century European flavor notwithstanding, the term occultism is thus used here simply to denote a scholarly preoccupation with one or more of the occult sciences, while 'science' awkwardly translates the Arabic term *'ilm* (lit., 'knowledge'), which rather corresponds to the broader concept of *scientia* or *Wissenschaft*, including *Geisteswissenschaft*.

the sayyid argued, is a proven means for repelling the invaders and restoring Manghit royal prestige. Irresistibly effective both medically and militarily, it had facilitated the Bukharan victory over the rival city-state of Shahrīsabz a generation earlier,² and more recently forced the retreat of a Russian expeditionary force from the border town of Jam.³ Historical precedent for these outcomes is moreover incontrovertible: the glories of the Timurid through Manghit lines over the past 500 years were propelled in the first place by a commitment to occultism, and the fortunes of individual dynasts, including Subhān Qulī Khan (r. 1681-1702) and Abū l-Fayẓ Khan (r. 1711-47), rose or fell in direct measure of their level of patronage of *jafr* specialists at court and on campaign. Amir Temür (r. 1370-1405) himself miraculously conquered Asia and rendered the Russians tributary precisely by reason of his unprecedentedly enthusiastic embrace of the science, thereby setting the standard for his successors for centuries.⁴ A return to occultism must therefore entail a return to power.

Needless to say, these claims present a problem for modern researchers. May they be safely dismissed out of historiographical hand, grist fit only for the anthropologist's mill? That is, should Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja be approached as a superstitious throwback spinning fantasies of lost glory in the face of overwhelming colonial modernity? An untutored shaman flogging his nomadic wares to sentimental, weak-minded, post-nomadic Turkic rulers in an urban Persianate environment in decline? Or was he what he claims to be—a representative member of the cosmopolitan Persianate religious-scholarly elite (ulama) tracing its intellectual and cultural genealogy back to the heyday of the Timurid Empire and beyond? And if so, what are we to make of his assertion of the central role of occultism in constellating high Turko-Mongol

2 Amir Muẓaffar's father, Naṣr Allāh Manghit (r. 1827-60), had finally defeated the rival city-state of Shahrīsabz at great cost in 1859, though it was not definitively integrated into the Manghit amirate until 1870, and that with Russian support. Further historical context is provided in the footnotes accompanying the translation in the appendix.

3 The shortlived, ill-fated Russian occupation of Jam occurred in 1878. For further details see the appendix footnotes, as well as Alexander Morrison, "Beyond the 'Great Game': The Russian Origins of the Second Anglo-Afghan War", *Modern Asian Studies* 50 (2016) (forthcoming).

4 Maḥmūd Khwāja's positing of an unbroken political continuity between the Tuqay-Timurids (here represented by Subhān Qulī Khan and Abū l-Fayẓ Khan) and the Manghits who supplanted them in the mid-18th century is striking, given that the latter deposed the former under Muḥammad Raḥīm Khan (r. 1747-59), and that (confusingly) the Tuqay-Timurids were Chinggisids, but *not* Timurids. The name of this lineage is derived not from Temür/Tamerlane, but rather from Toqay-Temür, son of Jochi, and grandson of Chinggis Khan (as opposed to Shiban son of Jochi, whose direct descendants ruled Central Asia from 1500-99).

Perso-Islamic imperial culture over half a millennium? Assuming we eschew (as we should) the triumphalist colonialist view that sorcery is merest superstition, more retrograde than religion itself, Maḥmūd Khwāja's status as a late 19th-century Bukharan scholar-occultist poses a broader and far more problematic question: Is magic a legitimate response to modernity? Can the modern itself be magical?⁵

This article deliberately ignores that most teleologizing and rupturous of categories, "modernity", arguing rather for *continuity*—specifically, the continuity of High Persianate culture well into the period of Russian colonialism. We here propose "High Persianate" as a heuristic for mapping a discrete cultural formation, quite distinctive aesthetically, literarily, intellectually, religiously, socially and politically, that crystallized in Timurid Iran and persisted robustly as a framework for the Persian cosmopolis, from Anatolia and the Balkans to Central Asia and India, for more than half a millennium. While this period roughly corresponds to "early modernity", we discard that vague handle here as too uselessly and terminally eurocentric, embracing in its stead the concept of *multiple temporalities*.⁶ It is this approach alone that allows us to analyze late High Persianate culture in Central Asia on its own terms, to resist the otherwise irresistible trap of teleology. That is to say, "High Persianate" as a more ideologically neutral periodization has the great advantage of not pre-saging the divergent paradigms wrought by colonialism and Islamic reformism respectively.

The High Persianate era did end, to be sure, though at different times and in different ways in the various regions of the persophone world. (In Iran itself, uniquely, the Islamic Revolution of 1979 may be seen as a partial resurrection of that era as remedy for the ills of unbridled modernization.) In the case of

5 On this question see e.g. Randall Styers, *Making Magic: Religion, Magic, and Science in the Modern World*, Oxford, Oxford UP, 2004; Michael Saler, "Modernity and Enchantment: A Historiographic Review", *American Historical Review* 111/3 (2006), pp. 692-716; Michael Taussig, *The Magic of the State*, New York, Routledge, 1997.

6 We here proceed on the assumption that the pluralistic nature of temporal frameworks, already significant enough within the bounds of a single cultural zone, can only increase in diversity across cultural zones. The concept of multiple temporalities, first developed by Reinhart Koselleck, has been adapted to the Islamicate context by Shahzad Bashir, who argues that "the whole notion of a single timeline as the central repository of Islam needs to be jettisoned in favor of a thoroughly pluralistic view in which all internal Islamic propositions with respect to the validity and authority of the past are appraised with an eye toward the ideological and affective intentions of the individuals and classes that had a hand in producing them" ("On Islamic Time: Rethinking Chronology in the Historiography of Muslim Societies", *History and Theory* 53/4 (2014), p. 522).

Central Asia, we argue that, far from suffering a cultural rupture under the brunt of Russian occupation in the late 19th century, High Persianate culture maintained an unbroken, vital and conscious continuity right up to the Soviet annexation of the region in 1920; it is only then that aggressive social reengineering was able to force a break, this primarily through the unprecedented disenfranchisement of religious-scholarly elites—like Mullā Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja and his peers.⁷ We further argue that this continuity was driven in no small part by a commitment to the occult sciences as common emblems of elite Islamicate-Persianate culture; that is, we begin with the inference that Maḥmūd Khwāja is a representative member of that culture (hence his titles Mullā, Sayyid and Khwāja) and is therefore a reliable informant.⁸ Such an approach has the virtue of allowing us to begin to make sense of the substantial corpus of Central Asian occultist texts thickly populating archives and libraries in the region—a corpus that has remained wholly untapped until now. Egregiously, not only have the occult sciences never been an object of study in the case of Central Asia, their existence has scarcely even been *acknowledged*, this despite their popularity in everyday life and high culture for millennia.⁹

This neglect of occultism, of course, is hardly unique to Central Asian historiography. Occultophobia infects most scholarship on the Persianate world specifically and Islamicate world generally, although this blinkering bias is slowly being whittled away as whiggish, eurocentric narratives are excavated, challenged and retired on multiple fronts, from poetry and philosophy to astronomy and law. Even in the context of Christianate Europe, where scholarship is otherwise far more advanced, occultism has been the object of rehabilitation for only a few decades, and that primarily in the fields of Renaissance studies and history of science.¹⁰ So while the derogatory label “pseudoscience” is still

7 It is important to note that many of these social engineers embracing the Soviet project were themselves Central Asian; this was not entirely a transformation imposed by outsiders, even if ultimate power was rooted in Moscow. See Adeeb Khalid, *Making Uzbekistan: Nation, Empire, and Revolution in the Early USSR*, Ithaca, Cornell UP, 2015.

8 This inference is based on prosopographic work on the ulama of Bukhara, as explicated in a separate section below, as well as in James Pickett, “The Persianate Sphere during the Age of Empires: Islamic Scholars and Networks of Exchange in Central Asia 1747-1917”, Ph.D. diss., Princeton University, 2015, ch. 4.

9 For an article that similarly exposes a near-total lacuna in a parallel field of Central Asian scholarship, see Devin DeWeese, “Muslim Medical Culture in Modern Central Asia: A Brief Note on Manuscript Sources from the Sixteenth to Twentieth Centuries”, *Central Asian Survey* 32/1 (2013), pp. 3-18.

10 The most accessible introduction to the field of Western esotericism studies, featuring dedicated academic units in Europe, is Wouter J. Hanegraaff, *Western Esotericism: A Guide*

uncritically deployed by many scholars—even those specializing in occult sciences like astrology¹¹—the decline model of Islamicate history is finally being put to pasture in a way that makes it difficult to argue any longer for occultism as epitomizing cultural decadence and its High Persianate florescence as proof of anti-modern regression.¹²

The present study, then, is a modest contribution to this new trend in the study of the Islamicate and Persianate world, as well as global colonial modernity more generally. Its primary goal is to provide a preliminary framework for analyzing similar texts from among the mass of surviving data on Central Asian occultism, including some basic intellectual-historical signposting from the broader Persian cosmopolis of which the region was an integral part up through the early 20th century.¹³ Given the thesis of Persianate cultural continuity from the 14th to the early 20th century, with roots extending centuries earlier, our analytical lens in what follows is necessarily wide-angle: it treats Maḥmūd Khwāja's 500-year period as a coherent whole. As we show, the sources do indeed bear out our scholar's bold claim as to a renaissance of occultism in the 15th-century Persianate world under the Timurids and a continued vitality and mainstream status thenceforward. Lettrism in particular persisted as a staple science among early modern ruling and scholarly elites, moreover, whether Timurid, Aqqyunlu, Safavid, Mughal, Uzbek or Ottoman, and featured as a fundamental component of Turko-Mongol

for the Perplexed, London, Bloomsbury, 2013; more theoretically meaty is Hanegraaff's *Esotericism and the Academy: Rejected Knowledge in Western Culture*, Cambridge, Cambridge UP, 2012, which proposes occultism as the primary Other against which modernity continues to be defined.

- 11 E. S. Kennedy, for instance, habitually refers to astrology as a pseudoscience, worth studying only because it involves non-trivial mathematical skill, and wholly ignores closely related sciences like geomancy; see e.g. "The Astrological Houses as Defined by Medieval Islamic Astronomers", repr. in E. S. Kennedy, *Astronomy and Astrology in the Medieval Islamic World*, Ashgate, Variorum, 1998, xv (pp. 535-78), p. 535.
- 12 A classic expression of this argument is Armand Abel, "La place des sciences occultes dans la décadence", in *Classicism et déclin culturel dans l'histoire de l'Islam*, ed. R. Brunschvig and G. E. von Grunebaum, Paris, Editions Besson, 1957, pp. 291-311. The decline debate is alive and well in the field of Central Asian studies, but mostly in regard to geopolitics and economics, and then primarily in the 18th century: Ron Sela, *The Legendary Biographies of Tamerlane: Islam and Heroic Apocrypha in Central Asia*, Cambridge, Cambridge UP, 2011, ch. 6; Scott Levi, "Early Modern Central Asia in World History", *History Compass* 10/11 (2012), pp. 866-878.
- 13 On the cosmopolis concept see Sheldon Pollock, *The Language of the Gods in the World of Men: Sanskrit, Culture, and Power in Premodern India*, Berkeley, University of California Press, 2006.

Perso-Islamic imperial ideologies and a standard part of courtly—and military—culture. Tellingly, Maḥmūd Khwāja's methodology as outlined in his letter to Amir Muẓaffar is virtually indistinguishable from that of his counterparts in Shiraz, Isfahan, Qazvin, Herat, Lahore, Fatehpur Sikri, Samarkand or Istanbul during the 14th–18th centuries, as manuals of letter magic produced or copied in these and other cities of the Persian cosmopolis indicate. That is to say, the terminology and methodologies our scholar-occultist employs were effectively systematized and canonized by the 16th century on the basis of 14th- and 15th-century Persian models, themselves dependent on earlier formulations in Arabic, and seem to have remained stable thereafter.

To address the questions Maḥmūd Khwāja's letter raises, we first discuss its reception in the Soviet context, problematizing the impulse to reduce occultism to shamanism and performing a postmortem on the decline of Central Asian occultism under Russian rule. We then provide an overview of the natural-philosophical, metaphysical and religiopolitical status of letter magic in the Persianate tradition from the early Timurid period onward, including the close association of lettrism with the House of the Prophet (and hence the purview of sayyids like Maḥmūd Khwāja) on the one hand and sufism on the other. (The meteoric rise of sufism to hegemonic status as a social, political, intellectual, literary and even economic category in the post-Mongol period has not a little to do with lettrism's great surge in popularity throughout the early modern Persianate world.¹⁴) The political applications of letter magic are here briefly examined, and its most influential exponents identified. Finally, we reconstruct Maḥmūd Khwāja's immediate social and intellectual context as a practicing occultist and member of the scholarly elite in 19th-century Bukhara, showing him to be a representative member of that elite on the basis of biographical dictionaries and miscellany notebooks (sg. *jung*). A translation and transcription of the letter itself are provided in the appendix.

“Superstition” and the Soviet Legacy: Occultism vs. Shamanism

The provenance of the document examined in this article reveals much about the Soviet categories of knowledge that are largely responsible for obscuring the history of occultism in Central Asia.¹⁵ Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja's

14 On the historically interdependent nature of occultism and sufism in the Islamicate world see below.

15 On the other hand, it should also be recognized that documents such as this are only cataloged and accessible to scholars today thanks to the considerable resources devoted

petition is part of a larger file (*delo* no. 1978) devoted to ‘predictions of astrologers’ (*predskazanii astrologov*) within a broader section of the catalog devoted to ‘religious documents’ (*religioznye dokumenty*).¹⁶ Rather than preserve the indigenous organization of the Qushbegi archive¹⁷ when the documents were uncovered in 1931,¹⁸ Soviet orientalists regrouped the documents contained therein by subject.¹⁹ These archivists were well-trained, but nevertheless collapsed all occult sciences into “astrology”—even though documents such as the one in question engaged an entirely separate discipline. In so doing they were unwittingly copying the strategy of earlier anti-occultism polemicists like Ibn Khaldūn (d. 1406), the last significant such in the Islamicate tradition, who famously, if unsuccessfully, attempted to strip the occult sciences of their natural-philosophical and metaphysical legitimacy by reducing them all to either magic or divination and conflating elite occultist practice with the popular perversity of extremist sufis, psychics and soothsayers.²⁰ (In stark contrast

to orientalist scholarship in the USSR. For an examination of how the Soviet government harnessed the residual scholars of the pre-revolutionary ulama, see Bakhtiyar Babadjanov, “‘Ulama’ v Sovetskom Institute vostokovedeniia”, in *Istoriia i istoriki Uzbekistana v XX veke*, ed. D.A. Alimova, Tashkent, Izd-vo “Navro’z”, 2014, pp. 301–348.

- 16 Opis’ for Fond i-126, “Koshbegi Emira Bukharskogo”, Tashkent, 1969, f. 128b.
- 17 Despite being one of the richest collections of Islamic chancery documents outside of the Ottoman Empire, the so-called Qushbegi archive (a *fond* within the Uzbek State Archive) has received scant scholarly attention, in part due to access issues. Two notable exceptions are Wolfgang Holzwarth, “Community Elders and State Agents: Īlbēgīs in the Emirate of Bukhara Around 1900”, *Eurasian Studies* 11/1-2 (2011), pp. 213–262; Andreas Wilde, “Creating the Façade of a Despotism: On Āqsaqāls in Late 19th-Century Bukhara”, in *Explorations in the Social History of Modern Central Asia (19th–Early 20th Century)*, ed. Paolo Sartori, Leiden, Brill, 2013, pp. 267–298.
- 18 As Holzwarth notes, “Around 85,000 Bukharan archival documents were recovered in 1931 in the basement of the ruined citadel of Bukhara. Most of these documents are not dated, but it has been established that the bulk of them relate to the period from 1870 to 1920” (“Community Elders”, p. 221).
- 19 This process of reclassification began in the Bukharan Museum shortly after the discovery of the document cache and continued under various archivists through subsequent decades—with the move to group the documents by etic topic initiated in 1955. See Mukhaiyo Isakova, *Stanovlenie i razvitie arkhivnogo dela v Uzbekistane*, Tashkent, Universitet, 2012, pp. 31–33.
- 20 That is to say, Ibn Khaldūn conceives of the occult sciences as inferior forms of miracles and prophecy respectively; the latter in turn serve as the basis of organized religion, itself the source of societal health in this life and salvation in the next, but the former should be made illegal by state fiat (see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Defending Geomancy: Šaraf al-Dīn Yazdī Rebuts Ibn Ḥaldūn’s Critique of the Occult Sciences”, in *Islamicate Occultism*:

with Soviet orientalists, however, even Ibn Khaldūn conceded that most occult sciences, despite being socially harmful, are undeniably efficacious, stating: “No thinking person doubts the reality of magic”.²¹)

While the Soviet orientalists in question presumably did not, like Ibn Khaldūn, intend to valorize religion by dismissing all occult sciences as mere forms of soothsaying, it is evident that they too found it useful to identify them with the divinatory and magical applications of astrology, historically the most popular of all occult arts east and west, so as to marginalize them more efficiently. That is to say, in constructing their classification scheme they pointedly ignored the whole of the Arabo-Persian encyclopedic tradition, wherein the occult sciences were consistently classified as integral parts of natural philosophy (*‘ilm-i ṭabī‘ī*), and increasingly the mathematical sciences (*‘ilm-i riḡyādī*) as well, from Fārābī (d. 950) and Ibn Sīnā (d. 1037) to at least the 18th century. The influential if conservative Arabic classification of the sciences (*taṣnīf al-‘ulūm*) of Ibn al-Akfānī (d. 1348), *Irshād al-Qāṣid ilā Asnā l-Maqāṣid*, for example, identifies the range of derivative natural sciences as follows:

Medicine (*‘ilm al-ṭibb*), veterinary medicine and falconry (*‘ilm al-bayṭara wa-l-bayzara*), physiognomy (*‘ilm al-firāsa*), oneiromancy (*‘ilm ta’bīr al-ru’yā*), judicial astrology (*‘ilm aḥkām al-nujūm*), magic (*‘ilm al-siḥr*), talismans (*‘ilm al-ṭilasmāt*), illusionism (*‘ilm al-sīmiyā*),²² alchemy (*‘ilm al-kīmiyā*), agriculture (*‘ilm al-filāḥa*).²³

As the Egyptian physician clarifies, these natural sciences treat of either simple bodies or composite bodies or both. Thus astrology treats of celestial simple bodies, and talismans treat of terrestrial or elemental simple bodies. As for composite bodies, illusionism treats of those that have no constitution (*mizāj*), while those that have constitutions are further subdivided into those that do not have souls (alchemy) and those that do have souls; here there are either insensible (*ghayr mudrika*) souls (agriculture) or sensible (veterinary medicine for animals, medicine for humans). Physiognomy then inquires into

New Perspectives, ed. Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Noah Gardiner (forthcoming 2016 as a special issue of *Arabica*)).

21 *Muqaddima*, ed. Darwīsh al-Juwaydī, Beirut, al-Maktaba al-‘Aṣriyya, 1995, p. 484: *wujūd al-siḥr lā miryā fīhi bayn al-‘uqalā’*.

22 The term *sīmiyā* typically denotes letter or divine-names magic, especially in Persian; Ibn al-Akfānī is here an outlier.

23 Ed. in Jan Just Witkam, *De Egyptische arts Ibn al-Akfānī (gest. 749/1348) en zijn indeling van de wetenschappen*, Leiden, Ter Lugt, 1989, pp. 13-70, p. 46 (Arabic text).

the inner states of rational human souls while they are conscious, and oneiromancy does the same while they are unconscious. That science which treats of both simple and composite bodies is magic.²⁴

To Ibn al-Akfānī and most other later Arabic encyclopedists, in short, the occult sciences are hardly occult—they are natural sciences like any other, and indeed form the backbone of natural philosophy, running the gamut from astrology (epistemologically the highest science) to magic (the most universal). The Persian encyclopedic tradition breaks with the Arabic to increasingly mathematicalize occult sciences like astrology, lettrism and geomancy (*‘ilm-i raml*) from the 12th century onward, but there too the emphasis is on their *scientific* status.²⁵ By contrast, in the Soviet archival context here under examination the rubric “astrology” is clearly both tropical and delegitimizing; the various occult sciences are a subset of religion and not sciences at all, and hence do not merit subdivision into their proper disciplines in the way that biology, chemistry and physics must be as branches of “real” science. The provenance of Maḥmūd Khwāja’s letter is thus illustrative of a much broader point: for the Soviets, religion was bad, but “superstition”—referring especially to sufism and occultism—was worse.²⁶

The categories in play throughout the magisterial *Sobranie vostochnykh rukopisei Akademii Nauk Uzbekskoi SSR* (SVR)²⁷ are significantly more gradated and nuanced than those in the archive catalog,²⁸ but nevertheless distant from those of the High Persianate tradition itself. Occultist texts were not covered

24 *Ibid.*

25 Thus astrology is formally classified as an extension of astronomy (*‘ilm al-hay’a*, one of the sciences of the quadrivium), geomancy or talismans an application of arithmetic, etc. See Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition” *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World*, 5/1 (2017), pp. 126–98.

26 On the sovietological (mis)understanding of sufism, see Devin DeWeese, “Islam and the Legacy of Sovietology: A Review Essay on Yaacov Ro’i’s Islam in the Soviet Union”, *Journal of Islamic Studies* 13/3 (2002), p. 310.

27 *Sobranie vostochnykh rukopisei Akademii Nauk Uzbekskoi SSR* (‘Collection of Oriental Manuscripts of the Academy of Sciences of the Uzbek SSR’), 11 vols., Tashkent, UzSSR Fanlar Akademiyasining Nashriyoti, 1952–1987.

28 This attention to detail comes as no surprises given that the volume’s editor was A. A. Semenov, an orientalist renowned both for his erudition and admiration for Islamic culture—especially in its Persianate (which he understood as Iranian/Aryan) guise; see Alfrid Bustanov, *Soviet Orientalism and the Creation of Central Asian Nations*, New York, Routledge, 2014, p. 57; Matthias Battis, “Soviet Orientalism and Nationalism in Central Asia: Aleksandr Semenov’s Vision of a Tajik National Identity”, *Iranian Studies* 48/5 (2015), pp. 729–745.

in the *SVR* until volume 5 (1960), at which point they were divided into several categories under the broader heading of ‘secret sciences’ (*skrytnye nauki*):²⁹

Magic and conjurations (*magiia, zaklinaniia*), *fāl* (*gadanie*, ‘divination’), *raml* (*gadanie na peske*, ‘divination in sand’), *jafr* (*magicheskije chisla*, ‘magical numbers’), *awfāq* (*sovpadeniia*, ‘conjunctions’), *ta’bīrnāma* (*sonniki*, ‘dreambooks’), *ilm al-qiyāfat* (*fiziognomika*, ‘physiognomy’), *shāna* (*gadanie na baran’ei lopatke*, ‘divination on a sheep shoulder-blade’), as well as a separate chapter on talismans (*talismany*).³⁰

Thus while the *SVR* is considerably better informed as to the range of occult sciences popular in Persianate Central Asia, it eschews both the Arabic encyclopedic tradition’s standard schema classifying them as part of natural philosophy, i.e., those sciences dealing with the sublunary, elemental realm, and the Persian one reclassifying some of them as derivative mathematical sciences, i.e., those sciences dealing with the celestial realm. (Idiosyncratically, the *SVR* classifies mathematics itself as a branch of natural science (*estestvoznanie*), but not medicine, which is assigned its own category.³¹) Yet even this attempt at marginalization was partially abortive; the Soviet orientalists in question found themselves unable to divorce astrology from astronomy,³² or alchemy

29 Tellingly, Semenov himself (i.e., the volume’s editor) was not entirely comfortable with this artificial category, qualifying the term *skrytnye nauki* as a provisional designation (*nazvanie uslovnoe*, lit. “conditional name”). The term *skrytnye nauki* appears to be a direct translation of *‘ulūm gharība* (and even closer in meaning to the alternate terms *‘ulūm khafīyya* and *‘ulūm ghāmīda*), given that other Russian terms (*okkul’tizm, spiritizm*) are used to refer occult sciences more generally (our thanks to Michael Gordin for clarifying this point).

30 *SVR*, vol. 5, p. 542. Note that this classification scheme is adopted in the catalog for the Tajik SRR National Library as well: A. Iunusov, *Fehrasti Dastnavishoi Tojiki-Forsii Kitobkhonai Davlatii RSS Tojikiston ba Nomi Abdulqosim Firdavsi*, 3 vols., Dushanbe, Vazprato Madaniati RSS Tojikiston Kitobkhonai Davlatii Respublikavii ba Nomi Firdavsi, 1971.

31 This schema is repeated throughout all subsequent volumes of the *SVR* (e.g., in vol. 11 (1987), physics is classified under *estestvoznanie* as well). Grouping the physical—that is, mathematical—sciences with the natural ones was unusual, but not unheard of, especially in early modern Russia. During the later imperial period, however, they were more likely to be classified under the rubric of ‘mathematical science’ (*matematicheskije nauki*), lending Semenov’s classification schema a vintage quality (our thanks to Michael Gordin for this insight).

32 Astrology is the only occult science that is included in the six volumes cataloging the parallel Tajik Institute of Oriental Studies manuscript collection (none of which otherwise cover *skrytnye nauki*)—here again likely due to the inseparability of astrology and astronomy in the Islamicate, not to mention Christianate, tradition. See *Katalog*

from chemistry, all of which are classified as natural sciences for the purposes of manuscript cataloging. But the overall occultophobic bias of the *svr* is clear. Earlier volumes of the catalog covered topics more legitimate from a Soviet perspective: chronicles, poetry, folklore, philosophy—all useful for nation-building projects. Even sufi genres received extensive treatment by volume 3 (1955). The majority of the occult sciences were left for last and explicitly separated out as chaff, with nomadic scapular divination and high scholarly sciences such as lettrism, geomancy and oneiromancy lumped together as ‘secret sciences’ of no relevance or connection, historical or otherwise, to “real” science. To the extent that inclusion of the ‘secret sciences’ was justified at all, it was on the grounds of ethnographic usefulness (*vazhnye dlia etnografii i smezhnykh distsiplin*), with the explicit object of inventing a nationalized culture divorced from its High Persianate framework.³³

This artificial division between rationalist, urban, Persianate culture on the one hand and the shamanistic folk magic of the steppe on the other has deep roots in the colonial period.³⁴ The first Russian ethnographers classified the forms of Islam they encountered on the steppe as a bastardized form of the religion, diluted with superstition, especially magic.³⁵ In his influential early 19th-century ethnographic work on the steppe people, for instance, A. I. Levshin cataloged all manner of indigenous sorcerers (*koldun*) and fortune-tellers (*gadatel'*).³⁶ By contrast, the forms of Islam rooted in Arabic scripture were held up as the “true” form of the faith. Scholars have demonstrated that the incorporation of Islam into the official tsarist Russian religious hierarchy in the Orenburg Spiritual Assembly in 1788 had the effect of reducing “Islam”

Vostochnykh Rukopisei Akademii Nauk Tadzhikskoi SSR, ed. A. M. Mirzoev and A. M. Boldyrev, 6 vols., Stalinabad (Dushanbe), Akademiia Nauk Tadzhikskoi SSR, 1960.

33 S. S. Semenov, “Preface” (*predislovie*) in *svr*, vol. 5, Tashkent, Isd. Akademii Nauk Uzb. SSR, 1960, p. 8.

34 This comes as no surprise, since Russian orientalism (*vostokovedenie*) enjoyed especially strong continuity through the otherwise stark disjuncture wrought by the Bolshevik Revolution; see Francine Hirsch, *Empire of Nations: Ethnographic Knowledge and the Making of the Soviet Union*, Ithaca, Cornell UP, 2005, ch. 1.

35 For one particularly clean, succinct conceptual separation between “true” Islam and shamanistic steppe traditions, complete with un-Islamic magic (*volshhebstvo*), see M. Vekimov, “Etnograficheskie materialy. Sledy shamanstva u kirgizov”, *Sredniaia Azia* 21 (1910), in *Turkestanskii Sbornik*, vol. 541, pp. 88–90. By contrast, Russian colonial works on religion and ethnography of the sedentary regions of Central Asia (namely Turkestan) emphasized textual, madrasa-based learning (see e.g. V. N. Nalivkin, “Tuzemtsy ran'she i teper'” (Izd. A. Kirsnera, 1913), in *Turkestanskii Sbornik*, vol. 584, pp. 85–156).

36 A. I. Levshin, *Opisanie kirgiz-kazatsk'ikh, ili kirgiz-kaisatskikh ordi i stepei*, vol. 3, St. Petersburg, Tipografiia Karla Kraia, 1832, p. 58.

to the narrow range marked out by the textual madrasa curriculum; this expurgated form of Islam was then promulgated throughout the region, including the steppe.³⁷ Nomadic beliefs and practices—including habitual recourse to magic—incongruent with those deemed rational were designated pre-Islamic, which made them both anathema to the scripturalist Muslims of the Spiritual Assembly and useful as emblems of “authentic” folk culture for later Soviet nation-building projects.³⁸

Nevertheless, the inadequacy of this bifurcation was evident even in texts written by orientalists, including the aforementioned Levshin. For instance, in his description of a “Kazakh” magician (*Kirgizskii charodei*),³⁹ he admits his status as an urbane religious scholar responsible for bringing magical practices to the steppe, describing him as follows: ‘He was a Tashkenter of a dignified appearance, wearing on his head a turban (*chalma*) and resembling a *kh^wāja* or mulla’.⁴⁰ Almost two centuries later, current anthropological research on Kazakh culture similarly undermines orientalist and sovietological categories: “The universality of divination in Muslim cultures defies attempts to trace its historical source, though its Persian vocabulary is a clue in the case of the Kazaks, who usually view it as an Islamic art, one of the ‘accepted forms of Koranic magic’”.⁴¹ Nevertheless, occultism, like sufism, began to be decoupled from the Islamic textual tradition under the brunt of Russian colonial influence—a tricky business, given its inextricability from High Persianate culture for over half a millennium, but eventually realized.

While the roots of this rupture are traceable to the colonial period, when Russian ethnographers and modernist Jadids coexisted with High Persianate scholar-occultists such as Maḥmūd Kh^wāja, sovietization succeeded in forcing a paradigm shift in a fashion most definitive.⁴² The 1920s and ’30s witnessed

37 Allen J. Frank, *Muslim Religious Institutions in Imperial Russia: The Islamic World of Novouzensk District and the Kazakh Inner Horde, 1780-1910*, Leiden, Brill, 2001, pp. 317-318; Robert D. Crews, *For Prophet and Tsar: Islam and Empire in Russia and Central Asia*, Cambridge, Mass., Harvard UP, 2006, p. 22.

38 Frank, *Muslim Religious Institutions*, p. 261. Similarly, Russian and Soviet scholars asserted pre-Islamic origins for sufi practices not firmly grounded in scripture; see Devin DeWeese, “Shamanization in Central Asia”, *JESHO* 57/3 (2014), pp. 326-63.

39 Russians referred to Kazakhs as Kyrgyz (or Kyrgyz-Kazakh) during this period to distinguish them from Cossacks.

40 Levshin, *Opisanie kirgiz-kazatsk'ikh*, p. 63. Here Levshin is recounting a description from an 1820 Siberian periodical.

41 Bruce G. Privratsky, *Muslim Turkistan: Kazak Religion and Collective Memory*, Richmond, Curzon Press, 2001, p. 214.

42 Even though occultism would seem an obvious target for modernists such as the Jadids, their small corpus of writings does not in fact feature extensive critique of magical arts at

an all-out assault on religion in the Soviet space, featuring the shuttering of mosques, sufi lodges and madrasas (together with their Christian equivalents) and the imprisonment of religious-scholarly elites.⁴³ When four Spiritual Directorates were opened in 1943 to provide for the limited practice of religion under state auspices, it was solely the reductive *scripturalist* strain of Islam that was awarded legitimacy—effectively continuing the project of the Orenburg Spiritual Assembly.⁴⁴ Put simply, sufism was persecuted but persisted in some measure, though in altered form;⁴⁵ the high occultist tradition was extirpated outright; and certain elements of Islamicate culture deemed useful were separated out and reengineered for the benefit of the newly-created Soviet nations.⁴⁶

Contemporary Islamic scholars in Uzbekistan testify to the totality of the disjuncture conceived by colonial ethnography and fully actualized under the Soviet Union. One such scholar, a Bukharan,⁴⁷ reported that while Islamic scripture and jurisprudence has been taught in Tashkent and at the famed Mīr-i ‘Arab madrasa in Bukhara since World War II, and Persian poetry and

large in their own society. This may have been because of the Jadids' tendency to focus on the practical (e.g., promoting literacy) over the theoretical (our thanks to Adeeb Khalid and Paolo Sartori for this insight). See also Adeeb Khalid, *The Politics of Muslim Cultural Reform: Jadidism in Central Asia*, Berkeley, University of California Press, 1998; Devin DeWeese, "It Was a Dark and Stagnant Night ('til the Jadids Brought the Light): Clichés, Biases, and False Dichotomies in the Intellectual History of Central Asia," *JESHO* 59 (2016), pp. 37–92.

43 See e.g. Shoshana Keller, *To Moscow, Not Mecca: The Soviet Campaign Against Islam in Central Asia, 1917–1941*, Westport, Praeger, 2001.

44 The Soviet muftiates were committed to "reconciling Islam with science and progress and guaranteeing its survival and revival in the modern scientific world" (Yaacov Ro'i, *Islam in the Soviet Union: From the Second World War to Gorbachev*, New York, Columbia UP, 2000, p. 133). To this end, Soviet Islam "was nourished by a categorical rejection of the predominantly Hanafi and Sufi traditions" (Ashirbek Muminov, Uygun Gafurov, and Rinat Shigabdinov, "Islamic Education in Soviet and Post-Soviet Uzbekistan", in *Islamic Education in the Soviet Union and Its Successor States*, ed. Michael Kemper et al., New York, Routledge, 2010, p. 224). See also Eren M. Tasar, "Soviet and Muslim: The Institutionalization of Islam in Central Asia, 1943–1991", Ph.D. diss., Harvard University, 2010.

45 The persistence of organized sufism under the Soviet Union has generally been overemphasized in the literature, but—unlike the high occultist tradition—elements of it did persist in altered form: Stéphane A. Dudoignon, "From Revival to Mutation: The Religious Personnel of Islam in Tajikistan, from de-Stalinization to Independence (1955–91)", *Central Asian Survey* 30/1 (2011), pp. 53–80.

46 Adeeb Khalid, *Islam after Communism: Religion and Politics in Central Asia*, Berkeley, University of California Press, 2007, ch. 4.

47 Interview conducted by James Pickett on 10 August 2014 in Bukhara, Uzbekistan. We have deemed it prudent to not reveal this scholar's identity, although he did not request anonymity, due to the sensitive nature of this topic in Uzbekistan today.

calligraphy passed on informally within limited circles, the occult sciences were willingly and deliberately forgotten. Religious scholars who were educated during the pre-Soviet period actively hid manuscripts of poetical and sufi texts, but for the most part chose not to preserve works on the occult sciences. Unprompted, our interviewee mentioned by name al-Būnī's famous grimoire, the *Shams al-Ma'ārif*, as a text mastered by his own teacher during the pre-Soviet period—knowledge that he refrained from passing on after the revolution. Meanwhile, forms of popular magic (e.g. *fālbinī*, 'soothsaying') are alive and well in Uzbekistan today, though frowned upon by scholars as sources of discord (*fitna*).

In other words, even though occultism remains a vital part of Central Asian culture generally (not to mention Iranian),⁴⁸ Soviet administrators and ethnographers—with the eager collaboration of state-sponsored religious scholars of a more doctrinaire bent—succeeded in transforming it into a strictly "low" tradition, thereby ghettoizing it. Or put metaphorically: colonialists and scripturalists together uprooted the mighty, spreading tree of occultism from the rich High Persianate-Islamicate loam that gave it such towering and enduring vitality, bucked its corpse for easy disposal, and declared the weak and scattered seedlings birthed of that violence to be but weeds. We may take as barometer of this dramatic cultural transmogrification the seminal Arabic grimoire associated with the 13th-century North African sufi-mage Aḥmad al-Būnī (a product rather of the 16th century, under Ottoman auspices), which was famed throughout the Persianate east for centuries.⁴⁹ In 19th-century Central Asia, it was considered intellectually relevant enough

48 The only studies to date of this question in the contemporary Iranian context is Alireza M. Doostdar, "Fantasies of Reason: Science, Superstition, and the Supernatural in Iran", Ph.D. diss., Harvard University, 2012; idem, *The Iranian Metaphysicals: Explorations in Science, Islam, and the Uncanny*, Princeton, Princeton UP (forthcoming).

49 As Noah Gardiner has established, the *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā*, to be distinguished from al-Būnī's authentic *Shams al-Ma'ārif wa-Laṭā'if al-'Awārif*, is largely a pseudepigraphic product of the late 16th century at the earliest, and to be partially associated with 15th-century Ottoman occultists like 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Bisṭāmī ("Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and His Readers Through the Mamlūk Period", Ph.D. diss., University of Michigan, 2014, pp. 33-37). It is more immediately utilizable than al-Būnī's authentic works, which are heavily sufi and esoteric in orientation, inasmuch as it represents a courtly, de-esotericized, adabized *summa* of sufi magic in its mature phase. In its immense popularity, the *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā* functioned—and continues to function—in the Islamicate world as the *Picatrix* did in the Christianate; ironically, the latter grimoire's Arabic original, the *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm* of Maslama al-Qurṭubī (d. 964), was far less seminal in arabophone (and persophone) regions, presumably due to the

to be copied numerous times, a standard reference for inquiring minds, and prestigious enough to be commissioned for translation into Turkic by the khan of Khiva himself.⁵⁰ In the present day, by contrast, this grimoire and the larger tradition it epitomizes is a distant and embarrassing memory.

Letter Magic and High Persianate Politics

To understand the magnitude of cultural loss that transpired in 20th-century Soviet Central Asia, we must go back to the birth of Islam itself. The astonishing spread of this new religion during the first century after the Hijra—essentially magical in its rapidity, according to contemporary observers—elevated early Islamicate culture to the unique position of heir to all the motley intellectual and religious currents of late antiquity, from the Hellenic, Egyptian and Hebrew legacies of the Mediterranean zone to the Persian and Indian legacies of the east.⁵¹ Islamicate occultism (to impose some semblance of epistemological unity on such a broad range of thought and practice⁵²) emerged organically out of this vast, complex landscape, an amalgam of high

relative geographical isolation of al-Andalus vis-à-vis the Islamicate heartlands during this period.

- 50 The *SVR* (vol. 7) lists no fewer than six Turkic translations of the *Shams al-Ma'arif*, albeit some of them partial: mss. IVANUz 9591, 7341, 6869, 7342, 6891, 7288. At least one of the translations was based on an 1880 Bombay lithograph (*SVR*, vol. 7, p. 277; ms. IVANUz 6891, f. 311b).
- 51 Chinese influences, mainly technological, material and aesthetic, also entered into the mix during the post-Mongol period. Garth Fowden has recently proposed a new, more expansive approach to late antiquity that acknowledges Islamdom as its most comprehensive heir; characterizing the emergence of Islam as the “keystone in the arch of the first millennium”, he identifies the (heavily occultist) 10th-century Brethren of Purity and Ibn Sīnā (d. 1037) in particular as the culmination of all the religio-intellectual currents of Hellenic-Abrahamic late antiquity (*Before and after Muḥammad: The First Millennium Refocused*, Princeton, Princeton UP, 2014). Pre-Islamic Central Asia was also an influential cultural zone, including for arts occult; although the cultural chain can hardly be described as uninterrupted, an 8th- or 9th-century fragment dealing with Turkic-infused occultist practices stands as one of the few surviving Zoroastrian documents in Sogdian (*The Wiley-Blackwell Companion to Zoroastrianism*, ed. Michael Stausberg and Yuhan Sohrab-Dinshaw Vevaina, Chichester, Wiley-Blackwell, 2015, p. 142).
- 52 It should be remembered, however, that the occult sciences are routinely identified as such in Arabic and Persian classifications of the sciences, biographical dictionaries, chronicles and other sources, so the term “Islamicate occultism” would appear to be warranted.

and low practices inherited, often piecemeal and in crosspollinating or recombinant fashion, from all these traditions. As such, each of the occult sciences as it emerged in mature, Arabic form has its own intricate and idiosyncratic genealogy whose strands are often beyond untangling. Some sciences, like astrology (*aḥkām al-nujūm*) and alchemy (*kīmīyāʾ*), reached their Arabic-Islamic maturity early, boasting clear Greek-Egyptian roots, though continuing to evolve thereafter; others, like geomancy (*ʿilm al-raml*), emerged only later, claiming descent from Hebrew and Indian models in equal measure (but more likely an indigenous Arabian and/or North African Berber technique).⁵³

Among the occult sciences that became permanently intertwined with Islamicate culture from its very inception, however, it is the science of letters (*ʿilm al-ḥurūf*), or lettrism, that underwent the most complex evolution; most significantly, it eventually emerged as the most *Islamic* of all the occult sciences despite its explicitly late antique, non-Islamic parentage.⁵⁴ While lettrism, like its coeval Hebrew cognate kabbalah,⁵⁵ is more properly an umbrella category covering a wide range of theories and techniques, some of them being transformed or shed over time, the term *ʿilm al-ḥurūf* (sometimes *khawāṣṣ al-ḥurūf*, ‘the active properties of letters’) is nevertheless regularly used in the sources to identify a discrete science from the 9th century onward. Given its 14-century history and ubiquity throughout the Islamicate world, an adequate survey of lettrism’s development is well beyond the scope of this article;⁵⁶ in this section we accordingly emphasize those elements and figures most relevant for understanding the outlook of our 19th-century Bukharan letter mage, Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja.

53 See Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Persianate Geomancy from Tūsī to the Millennium: A Preliminary Survey”, in *Occult Sciences in Premodern Islamic Culture*, ed. Nader El-Bizri and Eva Orthmann, Beirut, Orient-Institut Beirut (forthcoming).

54 Lettrism, like other occult sciences, was also styled a perennial science, an essential component of the *prisca sapientia*, through its association with Solomon and a host of other ancient prophets and sages, especially Hebrews like Daniel, Greeks like Pythagoras and Plato, Egyptians like Hermes, Iranians like Zoroaster and Indians like Ṭumṭum and Sāmūr (see e.g. Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest for a Universal Science: The Occult Philosophy of Šāʾin al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī and Intellectual Millenarianism in Early Timurid Iran”, Ph.D. diss., Yale University, 2012, pp. 318–328; Kevin van Bladel, *The Arabic Hermes: From Pagan Sage to Prophet of Science*, Oxford, Oxford UP, 2009).

55 Steven M. Wasserstrom, “Sefer Yešira and Early Islam: A Reappraisal”, *Journal of Jewish Thought and Philosophy*, 3 (1993), pp. 1–30; Michael Ebsstein, *Mysticism and Philosophy in al-Andalus: Ibn Masarra, Ibn al-Arabī and the Ismāʿīlī Tradition*, Leiden, Brill, 2014.

56 For a fuller treatment see Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest”, pp. 167–283.

Lettrism, as an umbrella science, encompasses the two modes of applied occultism as a whole in its basic division into letter magic (*sīmīyāʿ*) on the one hand and letter divination (*jafr*) on the other. Letter-magical techniques include most prominently the construction of talismans (sg. *ṭilasm*, *ṭilism*), usually defined as devices that conjunct celestial influences with terrestrial objects in order to produce a strange (*gharīb*) effect according with the will (*niyya*, *himma*) of the practitioner.⁵⁷ The engine of a talisman is usually a magic square (*waḥq al-aʿdād*), which may be populated with letters or numbers relevant to the operation at hand; these are designed to harness the specific letter-numerical virtues of personal names, whether of humans, jinn or angels, phrases or quranic passages, or one or more of the names of God.⁵⁸ (The latter operation, it should be noted, is a typical example of the sufi-occultist practice of ‘assuming the attributes of God’ or *theomimesis* (*takhalluq bi-akhlāq Allāh*)—hence the divine names as a major focus of lettrism, often termed for that reason *ʿilm al-ḥurūf wa-l-asmāʿ*, or even simply *ʿilm al-asmāʿ*, ‘the science of names’.) Letter divination, for its part, includes most prominently the construction of a comprehensive prognosticon (*jafr jāmiʿ*), a 784-page text containing every possible permutation of the letters of the Arabic alphabet.⁵⁹ From such a prognosticon may be derived the name of every thing or being that has ever existed or will ever exist, every name of God in every language, and the knowledge of past, present and future events—especially political events—to the end of time. This divinatory aspect of lettrism is associated in the first place with the mysterious separated sūra-initial letters in the Qurʾān

57 This is the definition standard from Ibn Sīnā onward; see his *R. fī Aqṣām al-ʿUlūm al-ʿAqliyya*, in *Tisʿ Rasāʾil fī l-Ḥikma wa-l-Ṭabīʿiyyāt*, Constantinople, n.p., 1298/1881, p. 75.

58 Like all major Islamic manuscript collections, the al-Biruni manuscript library in Tashkent contains a number of texts on magical squares. Notably, Mīr Maqṣūd Dihbīdī’s 30-page *Risāla dar Waḥq* appears to have been of local provenance and composed in the 19th century, since the town of Dihbīd outside of Samarkand was the headquarters of a powerful branch of Naqshbandī-Mujaddidī shaykhs (Ms. IVANUz 2572/XL (here referenced only via SVR, vol. 5, no. 3900)). On the Dihbīdī sufis, see Bakhtiar Babadzhanov, “On the History of the Naqshbandiyya Mujaddidiyya in Central Mawarānnahr in the Late 18th and Early 19th Centuries”, in *Muslim Culture in Russia and Central Asia from the 18th to the Early 20th Centuries*, ed. Anke von Kügelgen et al., Berlin, Klaus Schwartz, 1998; Anke von Kügelgen, “Rastsvet Nakshbandiia-Mudzhaddidiia v Srednei Transoksanii s XVIII—do nachala XIX vv.: opyt detektivnogo rassledovaniia”, in *Sufizm v Tsentralʾnoi Azii*, ed. A. A. Khismatulin, St. Petersburg, Filologicheskii Fakulʾtet Sankt-Peterburskogo Gosudarstvennogo Universiteta, 2001, pp. 275–330.

59 A completed comprehensive prognosticon has 784 pages, with 784 cells and 3,136 letters per page, resulting in 87,808 cells and 2,458,624 letters in total.

(*muqatta'āt*), similarly held to contain comprehensive predictive power, and to have inspired the basic lettrist technique of *taksīr*, separating the letters of words or names for the purposes of permutation.⁶⁰ Most letter-magical and letter-divinatory operations are profoundly astrological in orientation, moreover; careful attention to celestial configurations is essential for the success of any operation, and letter magic often involves the harnessing of planetary spirits (*taskhīr al-kawākib*) (together with angels and jinn). Fasting, a vegetarian diet, seclusion and maintenance of a state of ritual purity are also regularly identified as conditions of practice in manuals on these subjects.

Historically, lettrism first entered the Islamic tradition by way of two main vectors: 1) the symbolical cosmogonical speculations and sorcerous proclivities of so-called extremist (*ghulāt*) Shi'i circles of 8th-century Iraq, largely inspired by late antique Hellenic "gnostic" movements;⁶¹ and 2) the divinatory texts associated with the House of the Prophet, including *al-Jafr wa-l-Jāmi'a* and the Codex (*muṣṣḥaf*) of Fāṭima.⁶² It is the second vector in particular that prepared the way for lettrism's definitive *islamicization*, with 'Alī b. Abī Ṭālib and Ja'far al-Ṣādiq being routinely identified in later lettrist tradition as the science's supreme exponents for the Islamic dispensation. It then underwent a progressive *philosophicization* within a neoplatonic-neopythagorean framework, particularly on display in the 9th-century Jābir b. Ḥayyān corpus and the 10th-century *Epistles* of the Brethren of Purity; during this phase lettrism became associated with Isma'īlism in North Africa, which combined its cosmogonical and magical-divinatory applications as eclectically explored during the fraught emergence of Shi'ism. (The semi-Isma'īli *Epistles* famously declare magic, together with astrology and alchemy, the queen of all sciences and ultimate goal of philosophy.⁶³)

During the same period and primarily in the same place—North Africa and al-Andalus—lettrism underwent a process of *sanctification*, this entailing its recasting in specifically sufi terms rather than either natural-philosophical or

60 *Taksīr*, aka *'ilm al-kasr wa-l-baṣṭ*, can be awkwardly translated as 'fraction of numeration'. An instance of *taksīr* from 19th-century Central Asia is detailed for one Sayyid Qamar in the next section.

61 See William F. Tucker, *Mahdis and Millenarians: Shī'ite Extremists in Early Muslim Iraq*, Cambridge, Cambridge UP, 2008. The handle "gnostic", of course, is an almost unusably flabby one (our thanks to Dylan Burns for clarifying this point); see Morton Smith, "The History of the Term Gnostikos", in *The Rediscovery of Gnosticism*, ed. Bentley Layton, Leiden, Brill, 1978, pp. 796-807.

62 Hossein Modarressi, *Tradition and Survival: A Bibliographical Survey of Early Shī'ite Literature*, Vol. 1, Oxford, Oneworld, 2003, pp. 4-5, 18-19.

63 *Epistles of the Brethren of Purity: On Magic I*, ed. and trans. Godefroid de Callataÿ and Bruno Halflants, Oxford, Oxford UP, 2011, pp. 95-96.

Shi'i. This move was part of the larger sufi challenge to Shi'ism, whereby sufis began to position themselves as rival claimants to the Shi'i category of *walāya*, the 'sacral power' peculiar to the Imams; this category was therefore massively expanded by sufi theoreticians to designate Islamic sainthood in general. Most notably for our purposes here, and perhaps due to residual Isma'ili influence, the same sufi theoreticians elevated lettrism to the status of science of the saints ('*ilm al-awliyā*') *par excellence*: simultaneously a tool for cosmological speculation and for controlling creation, as well as vehicle of mystical ascent or return to the One.

This sanctification process began in the late 9th century and came to full flower in the work of two authorities in particular: Aḥmad al-Būnī (d. 1225?), the greatest mage of Islam, at least in his later reception, representing applied lettrism (i.e., letter magic); and Ibn 'Arabī (d. 1240), the greatest mystical philosopher of Islam, representing theoretical lettrism (i.e., letter metaphysics). The oeuvres of both authorities together thus represent the definitive synthesis of all the preceding lettrist currents; in their hands lettrism became the most quintessentially Islamic of sciences, yet without losing any of its old occult potency—indeed, that potency was amplified, now combining both philosophical-scientific and spiritual-religious legitimacy. In short, by the 13th century lettrism was emerging as a universal science, the marriage of ancient and modern, Hellenic and Islamic, the ideal vehicle for neoplatonic-neopythagorean philosophy on the one hand and the performance of sainthood on the other.⁶⁴

During the first phase of its development, then, the most influential exponents of lettrism operated in either Iraq or, slightly later, the Maghrib. Indeed, the *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'* appear to have been a vector in their own right for the transmission of occultist (including letter-magical) thought to the Islamicate west during the 10th century, giving rise to the burgeoning occultist scene that produced texts like the *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm* of Maslama al-Qurṭubī (d. 964); in Latin translation (the *Picatrix*) this work became the most seminal grimoire in Europe, though not the Islamicate world.⁶⁵ That distinction belongs rather

64 Although there is nothing in Maḥmūd Khwāja's letter that indicates this specifically, he, like his colleagues and forebears, would have almost certainly been an active member of one or more sufi orders, and hence a natural heir of this occultism-sufism synthesis as first worked out in the Maghrib in the 13th century.

65 On the *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm/Picatrix* see e.g. Godefroid de Callataÿ, "Magic in al-Andalus: *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'*, *Rutbat al-ḥakīm* and *Ghāyat al-ḥakīm (Picatrix)*," *Al-Qanṭara* 34/2 (2013), pp. 297-344; Liana Saif, *The Arabic Influences on Early Modern Occult Philosophy*, London, Palgrave Macmillan, 2015; Owen Davies, *Grimoires: A History of Magic Books*, Oxford, Oxford UP, 2009.

to (Ps.-)Būnī's *Great Sun of Knowledge* (*Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā*), which, unlike the *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm*, propounds a new, sanctified, fully islamicized system of letter magic⁶⁶—hence even Soviet-era Central Asian Muslim scholars' familiarity with this work, as well as its multiple translations into Turkic under the late Khivan amirate. But what were the historical and cultural factors that drove its ascent to canonical status even in the Persianate east, a primary reference for all practicing Muslim letter mages throughout the High Persianate period?

The 13th century was perhaps the most momentous in Islamic history, the scene of unprecedented upheaval and cultural ferment productive of new forms of religiopolitical legitimacy on the one hand and new ways of knowing and being on the other: it gave birth, in short, to the High Persianate. Not incidentally, it also marks the beginning of a great florescence of occultism, and especially lettrism, throughout the Islamicate world. And very like contemporary and later developments in Renaissance Europe, this florescence was equal parts philosophical and political in stemming. In the first place, the Mongol conquest of western Asia in the mid-13th century destroyed the caliphal-sultanic-jurisprudential model that had become standard in Islamicate societies, though seriously compromised by the time of the Mongols' arrival; into the sociopolitical vacuum thus created rushed the category of sainthood or sanctified power (*walāya*), particularly in the guise of sufism on the one hand and occultism on the other, which rapidly attained hegemonic status throughout the Persianate world most prominently (i.e., Anatolia to Central Asia and India).⁶⁷ From the 14th to the 17th century messianic sultans and saints competed fiercely with one another in laying claim to this sacral power: sultans became saint-kings (as in the Mughal and Ottoman Empires), and sufis became

66 Liana Saif, "From *Gāyat al-ḥakīm* to *Šams al-ma'ārif wa-laṭā'if al-'awārif*: Ways of Knowing and Paths of Power in Medieval Islam", in *Islamicate Occultism*, ed. Melvin-Koushki and Gardiner (forthcoming).

67 Orkhan Mir-Kasimov, "Conflicting Synergy of Patterns of Religious Authority in Islam", in *Unity in Diversity: Mysticism, Messianism and the Construction of Religious Authority in Islam*, ed. Orkhan Mir-Kasimov, Leiden, Brill, 2014, pp. 11-13. The case for sociopolitical continuity, rather than rupture, into the Mongol and post-Mongol period can just as easily be made—caliphal, sultanic and jurisprudential models certainly remained operative in many cases, though considerably transformed, with the political influence of religious scholars in particular burgeoning to an unprecedented extent. As this does little to explain the sudden and explosive ascent of *walāya* to hegemonic status in political, religious and philosophical discourses throughout the Persianate world, however, for our purposes here it seems preferable to emphasize those rupturous factors that made possible the very different forms of post-Mongol Islamicate imperialism.

sultans (as in the Safavid realm). Both parties in this imperial contest liberally patronized scholar-occultists for the same reason. It is here significant that Ibn 'Arabī, the foremost theoretician of *walāya*, was recruited as symbolic linchpin of early modern imperial ambitions, especially by the Ottomans; Yavuz Selim (r. 1512-20) declared Ibn 'Arabī the patron saint of the Ottoman Empire upon his conquest of Damascus in 1516. Sacral power aside, the (in)famous Ibn 'Arabian doctrine of the oneness of being (*waḥdat al-wujūd*) was likewise highly adaptable to expansive and universalizing imperialist ideologies.⁶⁸

This on the eastern front; different but complementary processes were afoot on the western front. Most notably, the 13th century marks the beginning of an unprecedented eastward flow of scholars and mystics from the Maghrib in the face of the Reconquista to the north and the rise of the puritanical Almohad regime (1130-1269) to the south. The Mongol invasion, of course, was simultaneously driving many of their persophone counterparts to flee westward. As a consequence, in the 13th and 14th centuries Ayyubid-Mamluk Egypt and Syria became the locus of a highly creative mixing of eastern and western intellectual and mystical traditions that had developed semi-independently for centuries.⁶⁹ The North African divinatory science of geomancy, for instance, Arabic answer to the *I Ching*, is unattested in Iran before the late 12th century, but there burgeoned in popularity from the Ilkhanid period (1256-1353) onward.⁷⁰ Ibn 'Arabī himself is the poster child for this new ferment: an Andalusian refugee in Damascus whose most important disciples were Persian, such that the Ibn 'Arabian tradition sunk far deeper roots in the Persianate east than the Arabicate west.

During this period, Mamluk Cairo emerged as one of the most important intellectual hubs of the Islamicate world, attracting scholars from far and wide, particularly Anatolia and Iran; in this capacity it became the epicenter of the

68 This doctrine was also invoked in challenge to imperialist ideologies, this most famously by Shaykh Badr al-Dīn of Simavna (executed 1416), the *khalīfa* of Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī in Anatolia; this jurist-occultist inspired the most successful rebellion in Ottoman history with his platform of radical Ibn 'Arabian monism as developed in his *Wāridāt*, to be expressed religiopolitically and economically in the form of pure communism and monotheistic communion among the impoverished Muslim and Christian peasantry of Rumelia and armed resistance to oppressive Ottoman elites.

69 See e.g. Elias Muhanna, "Encyclopædism in the Mamlūk Period: The Composition of Shihāb al-Dīn al-Nuwayrī's (d. 1333) *Nihāyat al-Arab fī Funūn al-Adab*", Ph.D. diss., Harvard University, 2012, pp. 44-45.

70 See Melvin-Koushki, "Persianate Geomancy".

occultist renaissance here under consideration.⁷¹ The crucial factor in this connection was the secretive study circles or esotericist reading communities that coalesced around the writings of al-Būnī, an Ifriqian sufi who appears to have been a member of the same networks as Ibn ‘Arabī.⁷² Following the general 13th-century trend (as well as the itinerary of al-Būnī himself), these circles appear to have migrated eastward from Ifriqiya and established themselves in Cairo by the end of that century. The manuscript record suggests that the study of al-Būnī’s works remained a modest, private affair until the mid-14th century, at which juncture and for as yet unknown reasons—though most likely due in the first place to the apocalyptic mood prevailing in plague-ridden Egypt and the social and political instability it signaled—interest exploded among Mamluk elites, who began to vigorously patronize the production and audition of Būnian texts;⁷³ this mainstreaming of sufi magic was then recorded by Mamluk encyclopedists like al-Nuwayrī (d. 1333) and al-Qalqashandī (d. 1418), whose open and decontextualized quotation of passages from al-Būnī’s works reflects an unprecedented *de-esotericization* and *adabization* of occultism.⁷⁴

These developments drew professional occultists to the Mamluk capital, including most notably one Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 1397), who became personal physician-alchemist to al-Ẓāhir Barqūq (r. 1382-99), a great patron of the occult sciences. Akhlāṭī, a persophone Kurdish *magus* hailing from Tabriz and rumored mahdi, stands as the most influential occultist of the 14th century: conscious heir of both al-Būnī and Ibn ‘Arabī, master to the most important occult philosophers of the early 15th century—and primary touchstone in the later Persian lettrist tradition of which our Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja is a part.⁷⁵ As a watershed figure, he is responsible for 1) the definitive synthesis of Būnian and Ibn ‘Arabian modes of lettrism; 2) the recasting of that synthesis in Persian guise; and 3) a renewed emphasis on the privileged position of descendants of the House of the Prophet as practioners of lettrism—hence Sayyid Maḥmūd’s similar Alid-centric claims of five centuries later.⁷⁶ (Akhlāṭī

71 On Cairo’s new status as the “political and cultural epicenter of the Muslim world”, see Muhanna, “Encyclopædism”, pp. 44-45.

72 Gardiner, “Esotericism”, pp. 70-72.

73 Gardiner, “Esotericism”, pp. 145-160.

74 Gardiner, “Esotericism”, pp. 281-293; Jean-Charles Coulon, “Magie et politique: événements historiques et pensée politique dans le *Šams al-ma’ārif* attribué à al-Būnī (mort en 622/1225)”, in *Islamicate Occultism*, ed. Melvin-Koushki and Gardiner (forthcoming).

75 Gardiner, “Esotericism”, pp. 75-77.

76 Sayyid-scholars were often singled out for special distinction over the centuries, some writers even identifying them as the *awliyā’ Allāh*, possessed of both comprehensive learning (*‘ilm*) and spiritual—including occultist—power (*walāya*) by virtue of Alid

remarkably asserts, for example, that only Ḥusaynī sayyids like himself may produce books of *jafr*.⁷⁷) That Akhlāṭī and his students lionized the Imams as the primary repositories of occult knowledge and sanctified power during the Islamic dispensation does not mean they identified as Shiʿi; they did not. Rather, they were forceful exponents of what may be called *imamophilia*, the major driver of the remarkable confessional ambiguity between Sunnism and Shiʿism that climaxed during the 14th and 15th centuries—which ambiguity is therefore partially a product of the highly imamophilic occultist renaissance of the same period.⁷⁸

What survives of Akhlāṭī's oeuvre, however, is scattered and unsystematic;⁷⁹ it therefore fell to his Anatolian and Iranian disciples to systematize and spread his approach. Akhlāṭī's *khalīfa* in the east was Ibn Turka (d. 1432), who, along with his student and friend Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī (d. 1454), dynastic historian to the Timurids, spent a number of years in Cairo studying lettrism with Akhlāṭī (as well as Shafiʿi jurisprudence with various professors of law).⁸⁰ Upon his return to Fars, Ibn Turka became a member of the court of Iskandar Sulṭān (r. 1409-14), Temūr's grandson, in Shiraz and then Isfahan, there beginning his career as qadi as well as his lifelong project of popularizing Akhlāṭian lettrism for the benefit of the Timurid ruling elite. (He is also responsible for the first *summa* of Islamic neopythagoreanism, his Arabic *Book of Inquiries*

descent; see Kazuo Morimoto, "The Prophet's Family as the Perennial Source of Saintly Scholars: al-Samhūdī on *ʿIlm* and *Nasab*", in *Family Portraits with Saints: Hagiography, Sanctity, and Family in the Muslim World*, ed. C. Mayeur-Jaouen and A. Papas, Berlin, Klaus Schwarz, 2014, pp. 106-124. Claims to sayyid status were likewise important to both Timurid and Safavid ideologies; see Azfar Moin, *The Millennial Sovereign: Sacred Kingship and Sainthood in Islam*, New York, Columbia UP, 2012, pp. 40-50; and Kazuo Morimoto, "The Earliest 'Alid Genealogy for the Safavids: New Evidence for the Pre-dynastic Claim to Sayyid Status", *Iranian Studies* 43/4 (2010), pp. 447-469.

77 Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest", p. 288.

78 Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest", pp. 69-77. This confessional ambiguity is termed Alid loyalty by Marshall Hodgson and Twelver Sunnism (*tasannun-i isnā-ʿasharī/davāzdah imāmī*) by Muḥammad Taqī Dānishpazhūh and Rasūl Jaʿfariyān.

79 A study of Akhlāṭī remains a major desideratum; the best treatments to date are I. Evrim Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks in Timurid Iran: Sharaf al-Dīn ʿAlī Yazdī and the Islamicate Republic of Letters*, Cambridge, Cambridge UP, 2016, pp. 114-140; and Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," pp. 47-51 and *passim*.

80 Akhlāṭī's primary disciples in Anatolia were the arabophone Shaykh Badr al-Dīn of Simavna (d. 1416) and ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī of Antioch (d. 1454); on the latter see e.g. Cornell Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom and New Sciences: Prophecies at the Ottoman Court in the Fifteenth and Early Sixteenth Centuries", in *Falnama: The Book of Omens*, ed. M. Farhad and S. Bagci, London, Thames & Hudson, 2009, pp. 232-243, 329-330.

(*K. al-Mafāhiṣ*), which remained influential in scholarly circles through the Safavid and Qajar periods; therein he proposed a new, Ibn ‘Arabian lettrist metaphysics to trump both peripatetic and illuminationist philosophy.⁸¹) While he had only mixed success—Shāhrukh b. Temür (r. 1409–47), who united the eastern and western halves of the empire under his control, appears to have been less than receptive—, Ibn Turka’s example shows that Maḥmūd Khwāja’s perception of the Timurid period as one in which lettrism vaulted to mainstream status as a major tool for empire-building was in no way a later fiction projected back onto the 15th century. Most notably, it was through the offices of Ibn Turka and Yazdī that Temür’s imperial legitimacy was reframed in both astrological and lettrist terms—a dual occultist platform that was to be popular among dynasts throughout the Persianate world until at least the 17th century, including the Mughal emperor Shāhjahān (r. 1628–57).⁸² Temür’s primary title, famously, was Lord of Conjunction (*ṣāhib-qirān*), or Starlord, as strongly asserted by Yazdī in his *Ẓafarnāma*; less acknowledged is the fact that Yazdī added to this astrological proof for the conqueror’s supremacy within Islamdom lettrist ones, characterizing him as a Letterlord (*ṣāhib-ḥurūf*) in equal measure, his glory inscribed in both the Qur’ān and the very fabric of the cosmos itself.⁸³

From this point forward ambitious Turko-Mongol Perso-Islamic sovereigns began to compete for the titles Starlord and Letterlord, eagerly patronizing those scholar-occultists qualified to recast the astrological and lettrist calculations in their favor. Later the same century, for instance, this service was rendered to Uzun Ḥasan (r. 1457–1478) by Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī (d. 1502), prominent Shirazi philosopher and “ideological mainstay” of the Aqquyunlu Empire, as John Woods has called him.⁸⁴ The term *ṣāhib-qirān* in particular remained a primary ideological point of reference for all rulers claiming a connection to Temür down to the late 19th century, especially in Central Asia; it was wielded

81 See Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest”. For a discussion of Sunni veneration of the House of the Prophet in Central Asia, see Robert D. McChesney, *Waqf in Central Asia: Four Hundred Years in the History of a Muslim Shrine, 1480–1889*, Princeton, Princeton UP, 1991, pp. 34–36.

82 Moin, *The Millennial Sovereign*, pp. 23–24, 36–60.

83 *Ẓafarnāma*, ed. Muḥammad ‘Abbāsī, 2 vols., Tehran, Mūza u Markaz-i Asnād-i Majlis-i Shūrā-yi Islāmī, 1336 Sh./1958, vol. 1, pp. 9–10. Unlike *ṣāhib-qirān*, the title *ṣāhib-ḥurūf* does not appear in the sources as such, but is here proposed as a term of convenience to describe a very real and widespread phenomenon; see Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest”, pp. 290–314.

84 John E. Woods, *The Aqquyunlu: Clan, Confederation, Empire*, rev. ed., Salt Lake City, 1999, p. 145.

by Nādir Shāh's (r. 1736-1747) biographers,⁸⁵ as well as by later chroniclers like Muḥammad Ḥakīm Khan Tora (fl. 1844).⁸⁶ Predictably, the Manghit amir Naṣr Allāh Khan (r. 1827-60) too was hailed as a Lord of Conjunction by Qāzī Mīr Sayyid Qamar, a known occultist.⁸⁷ What has yet to be investigated, however, is the extent to which astrological proofs of a given patron's imperial glory continued to be married to lettrist ones on the model of Yazdī and Davānī; but the present case study suggests that there is little reason to think that this linkage did not persist.

Davānī, not coincidentally, was a great admirer of Ibn Turka, and like him ranked lettrism at the top of his epistemological hierarchy, above logic, peripatetic philosophy and sufism in ascending order.⁸⁸ He also authored a distinctly Akhlāṭian manual of astrological letter magic, *A Spiritual Boon: On the Active Properties of Letters* (*Tuḥfa-yi Rūḥānī fī Khavāṣṣ al-Ḥurūf*), for the benefit of a Khaljī sultan of central India. In the introduction to this work he usefully summarizes the intellectual history of lettrism up to his day as an integral part of the *philosophia perennis*: Among the ancients, it was first taught by the prophet Solomon to the Greek sages Pythagoras, Plato, Aristotle and Apollonius of Tyana, thereafter becoming closely linked to both arithmetic and astrology. During the Islamic dispensation, lettrism was regenerated directly by the Qur'ān itself, an irruption of the uncreated divine word into human language, with Imam 'Alī standing as gatekeeper of its occult dimension; this he recorded in his comprehensive prognosticon. Imam Ja'far al-Šādiq then expounded upon this divinatory text, thereby inaugurating a tradition continued first by a series of sayyid scholars and then the sufi saints that succeeded them, including in the first place Ibn 'Arabī, al-Būnī, Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamuvayī and Abū l-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī.⁸⁹ All the foregoing strands were then synthesized in

85 These include most notably Muḥammad Kāzim in his *Ālam-ārā-yi Nādirī*, Tehran, Kitābfurūshī-yi Zuvvār, 1985, p. 575 and *passim*.

86 Muḥammad Ḥakīm Khān, *Muntakhab al-Tawārikh*, vol. 1, Tokyo, Mu'assasa-yi Muṭāla'āt-i Farhanghā u Zabānhā-yi Āsiyā u Āfrīqā, 2009, p. 344.

87 *Jung-i Qāzī Mīr Sayyid Qamar Šudūr*, ms. IVANUZ 2588, ff. 175b-176a. This *jung* is further discussed in the next section. For examples of various Khivan invocations of *šāhib-qirān*, see Shīr Muḥammad Mirāb Mu'nis, *Firdaws al-Iqbāl: History of Khorezm*, trans. Yuri Bregel, Leiden, Brill, 1988.

88 Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest", pp. 247-261.

89 Typically, the al-Biruni manuscript library in Tashkent contains an eight-page *fālnāma* or divinatory text copied in 1081/1681 in Akbarabad, India, and attributed to Ja'far al-Šādiq himself (ms. IVANUZ 2897/1 (here referenced only via SVR, vol. 5, no. 3879). This text discusses quranic bibliomantic consultations (sg. *istikhāra*) like those referenced by Maḥmūd Khwāja in his letter.

the late 14th century in Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī's definitive reformulation of the science as both Islamic and perennial—Davānī's primary point of reference. The Aqquyunlu philosopher, in short, like Ibn Turka and Yazdī before him, thus epitomizes the new breed of scholar-occultists deploying their expertise in service of empire in a manner that profoundly shaped Persianate culture for centuries.

This paradigm continued hale and hearty under the Safavids, although increasingly strict state control over religion and scholarship prompted many intellectuals, including many scholar-occultists, to leave Iran to seek patronage and employment in the Sunni Ottoman, Mughal or Shibani/Tuqay-Timurid realms; during the 16th century state-sponsored occultism therefore boomed across the Persianate world, crescendoing in the run-up to the Islamic millennium (1000/1592). Of those occultists who elected to remain in Iran and adapt to the new Twelver Shi'i imperial culture—and indeed to help *create* that culture—, Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī (fl. 1576) was perhaps the most influential.⁹⁰ The most productive Persian writer on lettrism of the 16th century, he plied his trade during the formative period of Shah Ṭahmāsb's (r. 1524-1576) reign, and at the height of his career dedicated several works to Ṭahmāsb's son and successor, Shah Ismā'īl II (r. 1576-1577), with a view toward elevating the new sovereign to the status of Letterlord. He is also identified in some sources as Shaykh Bahā'ī's (d. 1621) teacher in the occult sciences—a crucial point, given the latter's status as a charismatic architect of Safavid imperial culture in its transition from sufi to Shi'i claims to legitimacy. (Here the deeply imamophilic nature of the Persian lettrist tradition should be kept in mind.) Maḥmūd Dihdār, naturally, identified himself in the first place as heir to Akhlāṭī; but unlike Akhlāṭī's heirs of the preceding century, the Safavid lettrist produced the first Persian grimoire to rival Ps.-Būnī's *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā* (not coincidentally a product of the 16th century as well): *Keys to All Locks* (*Mafātīḥ al-Maghālīq*), a comprehensive, systematic work on letter magic and letter divination that remains popular in Iran today.⁹¹ Most significantly for our purposes here, its continued popularity in the persophone world from the 16th century onward means that this grimoire very likely served as one of Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja's primary reference works during his 42-year career as a lettrist.

As it happens, our most illuminating source for Persian letter-magical theory and practice during the 17th century is the Safavid-era recension of a seminal

90 Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Maḥmūd Dehdār Šīrāzī", *Elr*.

91 A Google search, for example, returns some 17,000 hits, and it is cited often in online Persian lettrist discussion forums.

late Timurid work, the *Qasimian Secrets* (*Asrar-i Qāsimī*) of Davānī's contemporary Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī (d. 1505), the famous Herati preacher, polymath and occultist extraordinaire. One of Kāshifī's five works on lettrism, the *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, which treats of *sīmiyā* and *rīmiyā*,⁹² does not appear to have been much copied in the late 15th and the 16th centuries; but in the 17th century its popularity blossomed.⁹³ Testifying to the magic manual's new cachet, in the early decades of that century it was anonymously expanded to include briefer sections on the three other sciences mentioned by the author but deliberately left aside: *kīmiyā*, *līmiyā* and *hīmiyā*.⁹⁴

Most significantly for our purposes here, in at least one version⁹⁵ these new sections include a wealth of detail as to the identities and activities of

92 Kāshifī explicitly states that the *Asrār-i Qāsimī* is conceived of as a translation-adaptation of two Arabic works in particular: the *K. Siḥr al-Uyūn* of Abū 'Abd Allāh Maghribī (aka *Kitāb Ibn al-Ḥallāj*), and the treatise *Uyūn al-Ḥaqā'iq wa-Īdāḥ al-Ṭarā'iq* by the 13th-century alchemist Abū l-Qāsim Aḥmad al-Simāwī (al-Simāwī). It should be noted here that Kāshifī always bases his works on others', and his exemplars are typically in Persian; see Maria Subtelny, "Sufism and Lettrism in Timurid Iran: Kāshifī's *Asrār-i qāsimī*" (forthcoming)—our thanks to Professor Subtelny for sharing a working draft of this article.

93 Kāshifī's scholarship was popular in Central Asia as well, and several different works are preserved in the al-Biruni manuscript library in Tashkent, including his astrological *Lavāyih al-Qamar* (ms. 460/1). His son 'Alī Ṣafī's lettrist treatise *Ḥirz al-Amān min Fitan al-Zamān*, which represents the state of the art during the early Safavid period, is also preserved (ms. 2795/1 and ms. 3060/1); most notably for our purposes here, in this work's preface 'Alī Ṣafī particularly recommends the science to rulers, for it enables the adept to bend others to his will, repulse enemies, and achieve other politically useful ends (*Ḥirz al-Amān*, lithograph, Lucknow, 1873, pp. 2-3; for a summary see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest", pp. 271-280).

94 We are indebted to Maria Subtelny for bringing this fact to our attention. *Kīmiyā*, *līmiyā*, *hīmiyā*, *sīmiyā* and *rīmiyā* often occur in a series, their initial letters being combined to produce the occultist motto 'the whole is a secret' (*KLHSR = kullu-hu sirr*). The definitions of these terms are not entirely stable from author to author; *sīmiyā*, for instance, can refer to anything from letter magic or divine-names magic to illusionism. Kāshifī, for his part, opens the *Asrār-i Qāsimī* by defining these five sciences as alchemy, talismans, planetary magic (*taskhīrāt*), illusionism (*khayālāt*) and terrestrial magic (*shu'badāt*) respectively (lithograph, Bombay, Malik al-Kuttāb, 1883, pp. 3-4). Cf. 'Allāma Ṭabāṭabā'ī's (d. 1981) definition of these five sciences in his *al-Mizān fī Tafsīr al-Qur'ān* (20 vols., Beirut, Mu'assasat al-A'lamī, 1971-1974, vol. 1, p. 241).

95 Unlike the Malik al-Kuttāb Bombay lithographs of 1889 and 1910, the 1883 edition incorporates under the heading of *līmiyā* Ibn Sāvajī's (Abū l-Maḥasin Muḥammad b. Sa'īd Nakhjavānī, fl. 1332) Persian translation of a text attributed to the ancient sage Ṭumṭum

practitioners of letter magic during the reign of Shah ‘Abbās (r. 1587-1629) in particular—in effect, a who’s who of Safavid occultism. The single most-cited authority is Shaykh Bahā’ī;⁹⁶ Akhlāṭī runs a close second.⁹⁷ Notably, the philosopher and Safavid *ṣadr* Mir Ghiyāṣ al-Dīn Manṣūr Dashtakī (d. 1549) pirouettes on the page as personal lettrist to Shah Ṭahmāsb.⁹⁸ A number of other prominent scholars and shaykhs feature as master letter mages, and great emphasis is placed on their prized and potent support of the various political actors of their day. Even Ibn Sīnā (Shaykh Bū ‘Alī), second father of peripateticism and no booster of the occult sciences, is cited as a lettrist to be feared⁹⁹—a reputation he preserved in 19th-century Central Asia.¹⁰⁰

Maḥmūd Dihdār, unsurprisingly, is one of the first authorities mentioned. In his case too his service to the Safavid ruling elite is the salient point:

On seeking an audience with kings (*dīdan-i mulūk*): One must inscribe a 4×4 square on gold and populate it with the numbers of the holy verse, *God is All-gentle (laṭīf) with His servants, providing for whomsoever He will*

al-Hindī and entitled *Ḥall al-Mushkilāt*, treating of talismans and various magical operations (Āqā Buzurg Ṭihirānī, *al-Dhar’ā ilā Taṣānīf al-Shī’a*, 25 vols. in 28, Beirut, Dār al-Aḍwā’, 1983, vol. 7, p. 74); numerous anecdotes about the uses to which these talismans and operations were put by Safavid-era scholars may be supposed to have been added by an anonymous early 17th-century author.

96 See e.g. Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, lithograph, Bombay, Malik al-Kuttāb, 1883, pp. 87, 98, 99, 102, 105; and Pierre Lory, “Kashifī’s *Asrār-i Qāsimī* and Timurid Magic”, *Iranian Studies* 36/4 (2003), p. 537 (note that Lory’s identification of this Shaykh Bahā’ al-Dīn Muḥammad with Bahā’ al-Dīn Naqshband is incorrect). As Shaykh Bahā’ī is referred to as having died (his name is sometimes followed by the eulogistic phrase *qaddasa sirra-hu*), the year 1621 is the expanded version’s *terminus post quem* (Subtelny, “Sufism and Lettrism”), while the fact that Shah ‘Abbās (d. 1629) appears to be spoken of in the present tense (he is never mentioned by name, unlike Shah Ṭahmāsb and Shah Ismā’īl, a sign of deference to a living superior) suggests that it may be a product of the 1620s or perhaps 1630s—or at least deliberately cast as such.

97 See e.g. Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, p. 98.

98 See e.g. Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, pp. 85, 92, 97, 104.

99 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, p. 89.

100 One 79-page *fālnāma* (copied 1851) preserved in the al-Biruni manuscript library in Tashkent is prefaced with an anecdote about the magical deeds of Ibn Sīnā. After Ibn Sīnā triumphed over a group of nefarious sorcerers, the ruler of Kashmir asked him to write a book detailing his miraculous powers—which resulted in this 114-chapter book (ms. IVANUZ 2504/11 (here referenced only via SVR, vol. 5, no. 3883)). Most famously, the important occultist manual *Kunūz al-Mu’azzimūn* was likewise attributed to Ibn Sīnā well after the fact (ed. Jalāl al-Dīn Humā’ī, Tehran, n.p., 1331 Sh./1952).

(Cor 42, 19) [= 998], combining these with the letters of his own name. He should then insert the resulting number in the square, refraining from speech in the process. Of these two names [i.e., his own and the king's], he should write one at the top of the square and one at the bottom . . . ,¹⁰¹ and carry [the talisman] on his person. Thus when he sees the king he will be honored and shown generosity. This square was developed by Mawlānā Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī, who constructed one for Amīr Khan;¹⁰² as a result he attained control over all of Fars (*imārat u iyālat-i Fārs-rā yāft*).¹⁰³

But lettrists were not simply props to power—they were also checks on that power. Here Shaykh Bahā'ī is presented as protecting hapless souls from royal wrath by exerting occult control over the shah's moods:

[On negating the anger of kings]: If a king becomes angry with someone such that the latter is at risk of execution, he should use this same number to inscribe this square on gold at an auspicious hour and donate some sweetmeats (*andakī shūrīnī*) to the poor; in the same hour the king's wrath will turn to graciousness and clemency. My own departed teacher saved many individuals from execution by virtue of this square, and Shaykh Bahā' al-Dīn Muḥammad [al-'Āmilī] (may He sanctify his secret!) constructed one for Āqā 'Ināyat [Allāh], who as a result was protected from being the object of royal displeasure as long as he lived.¹⁰⁴

Needless to say, the ability to manipulate the mind and emotions of sovereigns was a double-edged sword. On the one hand, it made lettrists natural allies to ambitious up-and-comers seeking to unseat their superiors; on the other hand, it suggested them as a dangerous liability to any political players who, having

101 Two words here are indecipherable.

102 This figure would seem to be Amīr Khan or Amīr Beg 11 Mawṣillu, a former Aqquyunlu commander who joined the Qizilbash in 1507 and became one of the most important officers of the Safavid state, holding such posts as guardian of prince Ṭahmāsb and governor-general of Khurasan (see Woods, *The Aqquyunlu*, pp. 12, 166, 192–193). However, as Amīr Khan died in 1522, Maḥmūd Dihdār, at the height of his career between 1569–1576, would presumably have been no more than an infant at the height of the amir's own career. But if there is any truth to the relationship posited here between Amīr Khan and Maḥmūd, this suggests that the latter may have been born in the last decades of the 15th century and lived for almost a hundred years.

103 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, pp. 85–86.

104 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, p. 86.

achieved power, were more concerned with maintaining the status quo. Here one of Akhlāṭī's famous techniques is redeployed for the benefit of a young, ambitious Ṭahmāsb:

On bending the hearts of kings and rulers to one's will (*taskhīr-i qulūb-i salāṭīn u ḥukkām*): One should inscribe these exalted letters—A Ḥ D R S Ṣ Ṭ ' K L M W H L A—on a piece of deerskin and insert it under one's ring (*angushtarī*) at an auspicious hour, particularly when the sun is in exaltation. This is an experientially verified operation (*az a'māl-i mujar-raba*) developed by Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī. Shaykh 'Abd al-'Ādil advised Mawlānā Maḥmūd Daylamī to construct [such a talisman] for Shah Ṭahmāsb. If one can use a piece of lionskin the operation will be even more effective.¹⁰⁵

What all parties could agree on, however, was the incontrovertible effectiveness of lettrist talismans in the pursuit of power. The first passage below presents Mīr Ghiyāṣ al-Dīn Dashtakī as talisman-maker extraordinaire to Shah Ṭahmāsb; the second attributes the extraordinary success of the Qizilbash amirs Murshid Quli Khan (d. 1632) and Allāh Virdi Khan (d. 1613) to their similar dependency on talismans:

On attaining authority over people (*tasalluṭ u buzurgī bar khalāyiq*): One must engrave a 5×5 square on copper at an auspicious hour when Venus is in exaltation, populating it with the number of the holy verse *God acts as He wishes and judges as He desires* [= 958].¹⁰⁶ (This is indeed a rare operation and productive of wonders.) On the back of that square one should write the names *O Ḥaḥṭayā'il*, *O Ḥanẓayā'il*, *O Mūkayā'il*!, this under Venus; and the operation will be most effective if Venus is in exaltation. This seal talisman (*muhr*) is one of the better-known operations performed by the esteemed sayyid Mīr Ghiyāṣ al-Dīn Shīrāzī, who constructed one for Shah Ṭahmāsb Ḥusaynī Mūsavī Ṣafavī. The bearer of this talisman will find all his peers and indeed all men to be obedient to him and he shall be honored by all. My own teacher constructed this talisman for a certain renowned governor (*navvāb-i 'aliyya-yi 'āliya*) [i.e., Allāh

105 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, p. 89.

106 This "verse" appears to be a conflation of two separate quranic phrases from Cor 14, 27 and Cor 5, 1.

Virdi Khan?], who then became ascendant over all rulers (*khavānīn-i mu'azzama*) and men and women alike.¹⁰⁷

On attaining authority over people and one's peers: One must construct a square on gold on Sunday, populating it with the number 958, beginning from the 16th cell. The effectiveness of this operation has been thoroughly verified by experience (*bisyār mujarrab ast*). At the beginning of the process one should perform a ritual ablution, then take various types of precious stones (*aqsām-i javāhir*), preferably rubies (*yāqūt*), and hold them in your mouth; it is best if the precious stones have a hole bored into them. Upon finishing the operation one should not speak to anyone, and one should inscribe the holy verse *God suffices as a witness: Muḥammad is the messenger of God* (Cor 48, 28-29) on the margin of the square. This operation was famously performed by Mawlānā 'Abd al-Laṭīf Gīlānī, who constructed [such a talisman] for Murshid Quli Khan in Mashhad (*maq-dis*), who then achieved ascendancy over all the amirs and the Qizilbash. When one finishes the operation one should give a sizable amount in charity for the poor. My own departed teacher (*ustād-i marhūm*) constructed one for Allāh Virdi Khan after the king had appointed him governor (*dārūgha*) of Isfahan, who then wore it on his arm; in short order he gained control over all Fars and attained to the greatest glory imaginable.¹⁰⁸

This, then, was the state of the art in the 17th century, when, Maḥmūd Khwāja asserts, Subḥān Quli Khan too employed letter mages as members of his personal retinue to great effect. While examples of the political applications of lettrism could be multiplied, those cited above clearly indicate the emergence of a stable, canonical form of Persian lettrist practice during the 14th-17th centuries, with the tradition's point of origin being early Timurid Iran by way of late Mamluk Cairo. As indicated by our Bukharan interviewee of the previous section, the Ifriqian-Cairene sufi-mage al-Būnī remained very much a living authority in the Persianate east (as in the Islamicate world more generally) into the 20th century; such impressive intellectual continuity over seven centuries, however, was made possible only through his definitive Persian reformulation by a series of influential Iranian occultists, including in the first place Akhlāṭī and his scholarly heirs Ibn Turka, Davānī, Kāshifī and Maḥmūd Dihdār. Indeed, the latter's *Mafātīḥ al-Maghālīq* seems to have essentially supplanted the *Shams al-Ma'ārif al-Kubrā* in Iran today, where the High Persianate

107 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, pp. 89-90.

108 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, p. 90.

occultist tradition has undergone a transformation very different from what transpired in Central Asia: on a popular level, it has been significantly diluted through admixture with syncretizing New Age spiritualities imported from Europe and America, yet also persists as an integral tradition within certain seminary circles, defended by the likes of ‘Allāma Ṭabāṭabā’ī (d. 1981), ‘Allāma Ḥasan Ḥasanzāda Āmulī (b. 1928) and other redoubtable ayatollahs.¹⁰⁹ This, of course, is in extreme contrast to the tradition’s fate in Soviet Central Asia, which further highlights the status of post-revolutionary Iran as a unique case in this as in other respects, and its usefulness as a control in the study of Islamicate “magical modernities”.

Given the extreme neglect of occultism as an object of scholarly inquiry among Islamicists and historians of Central Asia alike, however, it is not yet possible to say how or when this Timurid-Aqquyunlu-Safavid lettrist tradition may have been transplanted to Transoxania in particular, nor to describe its further development after the early 17th century.¹¹⁰ But transplanted it clearly was, and thrive it did: the very existence in late 19th-century Bukhara of self-assured scholar-occultists like Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja is otherwise inexplicable.¹¹¹ At the same time, his invocation of Temūr as model reflects the revival of Timurid prestige in Central Asia in the 18th or 19th century after two and a half centuries of Chinggisid dominance; while lettrism may well have thrived there in the interim as an elite intellectual discourse, it is equally possible that its Timurid associations led to its marginalization during this period.¹¹² As that

109 See Doostdar, *The Iranian Metaphysicals*. The profound lettrist proclivities of the Shaykhi, Babi and Baha’i movements of the 18th-19th centuries should also be noted in this connection (Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest”, p. 281).

110 Jane Murphy’s findings on the continuity of high Islamicate occultism in late Ottoman Egypt offer a useful comparison here; see her “Improving the Mind and Delighting the Spirit: Jabarti and the Sciences in Eighteenth-Century Ottoman Cairo”, Ph.D. diss., Princeton University, 2006. As she there notes (pp. iii-iv): “Within the ranks of eighteenth-century Cairene religious scholars, study of the *gharib* sciences produced extremely close attachments between students and teachers; in the larger society, expertise in the *gharib* sciences served as an important link between members of the ulama and the ruling Ottoman and Mamluk classes. Far from exhibiting the timeless opposition of ‘Islam’ to ‘Science’, eighteenth-century Cairo saw many of the most prominent members of the religious class deeply involved in magico-scientific practices”.

111 This stands as further evidence in support of Robert McChesney’s critique of the “barrier of heterodoxy” separating Safavid Iran and Transoxania: “‘Barrier of Heterodoxy’?: Rethinking the Ties Between Iran and Central Asia in the 17th Century”, *Pembroke Papers* 4 (1996), pp. 231-267.

112 Our thanks to Devin DeWeese for this observation. Adequately assessing the state of occultism during the post-Timurid, pre-Manghit period, however, would require serious

may be, however, the above survey of the Persian lettrist tradition suggests that Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja's claims as to the unbroken historical continuity of that tradition from Temür onward were founded on well-known fact, not wishful fiction, and his sense of duty to the Manghit ruling elite as a practicing occultist rooted in venerable precedent.

Ulama as Occultists Extraordinaire

Mullā Maḥmūd Khwāja, our letter mage and sayyid, was thus a card-carrying member of an august occultist—and deeply Islamic—tradition long predating the rise of the dynasty to which he offered his services. But how healthy was that tradition in his own day? Was he an odd man out, a latter-day exponent of a dying art, a relic in a strangling culture?

The answer, quite simply, is no. To the contrary, surviving sources indicate that occultism was widely practiced by the ulama of Bukhara, an ordinary element of cultural and religious life. Individual occult sciences, such as lettrism, were not the domain of specialized magicians at the margins of high society, but rather one of many forms of knowledge mastered by the ulama alongside jurisprudence (*fiqh*), poetry, hadith, tafsir, etc. Moreover, the Russian conquest of Bukhara in 1868 in no way marked a rupture with occultist traditions cultivated in Central Asia since the Timurid period. If anything, the protectorate era (1868–1920) was a high point for Persianate scholarly culture—including occultism as an important subset of that culture.¹¹³

Some two to five percent of the most prestigious ulama captured in late Bukharan biographical dictionaries (sg. *tazkirat*)¹¹⁴ are identified as specialists

scholarly investigation beyond the scope of this study. Nevertheless, we here tentatively favor the argument for continuity (rather than for marginalization followed by later resurgence, as Maḥmūd Khwāja would have it) on the basis of anecdotal evidence. The scholars described in Malihā Samarqandī's biographical dictionary of 1691, for instance, were great practitioners of the occult sciences—including, of course, letter magic (*Tazkira-i Muzakkir al-Aṣḥāb, yā Tazkirat al-Shu'arā-yi Malihā-yi Samarqandī*, ed. Kamal al-Din S. Aini, Dushanbe, Sifārat-i Jumhūrī-yi Islāmī-yi Īrān dar Tājīkistān, 1385 Sh./2006; see e.g. p. 63).

113 That this cultural efflorescence coexisted with military defeat is but one of the many paradoxes of colonialism.

114 The standard spelling in Iran and South Asia is *tazkira*, but later Central Asian sources, which tend to change *-a* endings to *-at*, prefer *tazkirat*.

in various occult sciences.¹¹⁵ (Compare here Jane Murphy's larger figure of 12 to 15 percent for the incidence of scholar-occultists in biographical dictionaries covering 18th-century Ottoman Egypt.¹¹⁶) At first glance, this may seem like a rather small figure, but two factors must be kept in mind. First, these biographical dictionaries include only the most famous and esteemed scholars who rose to prominence in the city of Bukhara. Second, this percentage includes only those individuals who were specifically singled out for their mastery of the occult sciences. The proportion of occultists in the sample is roughly on par with those practicing medicine, and only slightly less than those identified as an imam (just over five percent). Yet we can assume that more than five percent of the sample led prayer as imams, just as we can assume that hadith mastery was far more common an accomplishment than is explicitly referenced in *tazkirats*. Because such practices were common to the point of being taken for granted, imams were only singled out in biographical dictionaries if they led an especially prestigious mosque, and hadith mastery was only specifically mentioned if the scholar in question was unusually renowned for it. We can therefore assume a similar principle for the occult sciences: mastery of them was far more widespread than even the remarkable figure of five percent would suggest. As such, we should not take Maḥmūd Khwāja's testimony as to the diminished royal patronage of *jafr* specifically as evidence for a marginalized role for occultism in colonial-era Central Asia more generally.

To the evidence of biographical dictionaries for the continued vitality of the occult sciences may be added that found in another genre: the *jung*.¹¹⁷ These miscellany notebooks defy easy categorization; while they most often served as practical legal references for qadis and muftis, *jungs* could be devoted to virtually any subject, including medicine.¹¹⁸ Whatever the core function of a given

115 These figures are drawn from a broader prosopographical inquiry aggregating three such biographical dictionaries in particular: Qārī' Raḥmat Allāh b. 'Ashūr Muḥammad al-Bukhārī, *takhalluṣ Vāziḥ*, *Tuḥfat al-Aḥbāb fī Tazkirat al-Aṣḥāb*, ms. IVANTaj 483 (late 1860s, 133 scholars included in sample); Ḥājji Ni'mat Allāh Muḥtaram, *Tazkirat al-Shu'arā-yi Muḥtaram*, ms. IVANUz 2252/11 (1908, 187 scholars included in sample); and Sharīf Jān Makhdūm Ṣadr Ṣiyyā', *Tazkirat al-Khaṭṭāṭin-i Mīrzā Muḥammad Sharīf al-Mutakhallīṣ bi-l-Ṣiyyā'*, ms. IVANUz 1304/111 (early 1900s, 107 scholars included in sample).

116 "Aḥmad al-Damanhūrī (1689-1778) and the Utility of Expertise in Early Modern Ottoman Egypt", *Osiris*, n.s. 25 (2010), p. 90.

117 According to Dihkhudā's *Lughatnāma* (s.v.), this word may be a calque from the Chinese word for ship (*junk*), translated directly from the Arabic word for ship (*safīna*) used in Iran for *ghazal* collections.

118 For an example of a medical *jung*, see ms. IVANUz 9769. Even this medical *jung*, however, has instances of *jafr* inscribed next to the medicinal remedies (e.g. f. 78a).

jung, however, they nearly always reflected the eclectic interests and functions of the ulama that produced them. Even strictly legal *jungs* are peppered throughout with scrawls of poetry and scribbled notes about sufism, medicine and—not infrequently—various occult sciences, including geomancy, astrology and lettrism.¹¹⁹ (Although such juxtapositions have yet to be investigated, they strongly imply that some judges were in the habit of performing geomantic readings or lettrist analyses to help them decide court cases.) This evidence corroborates that of the biographical dictionaries, not to mention chancery documents such as Maḥmūd Khwāja's letter, and demonstrates the wholly mainstream status of high occultism in scholarly circles: a basic facility in the field was common among strata of ulama far broader than the super-elite captured in biographical dictionaries.

Three examples of such occultist miscellanea must here suffice. Following an invocation of the legendary figure of Khizr, for instance, one *jung* includes a talismanic recipe whereby the practitioner may augur whether or not an illness will prove fatal by placing an inscribed eggshell under the pillow of the afflicted.¹²⁰ Similarly, another qadi's notebook includes instructions for preparing a charm (*ta'wīz*)—presumably a love charm—as follows:

Write this charm [inscribed with the series of numbers below] on a piece of paper and insert it into a sheep's heart. Then take a piece of the cloak belonging the person in question (*pāra-yi dalaq az jāma-yi ān kas*) to serve as a piece of cloth (*kirbās*). Then wet the cloth, roll the heart up inside of it, and place it under a fire. This is a charm tried and true (*mujarrab*).¹²¹

Charms and talismans aside, most forms of letter magic and letter divination make routine appearances in *jungs* as well. Not surprisingly, the *jung* prescribing the above mentioned charm also includes numerous sections on *jafr*,

119 To be clear, most *jungs* seemed to have a central focus, usually law, so it would be misleading to suggest that the full range of activities of the ulama were represented in equal part. Rather, the bulk of most such notebooks were devoted to legal issues, with entries on other subjects, such as geomancy or *jafr*, haphazardly scattered throughout.

120 Untitled *jung* cataloged as "Tetrad's razlichnymi zapisiami", ms. Rare Books Collection of the National Library of Russia (Rossiskaia Natsional'naia Biblioteka, Otdel Rukopisei), Saint Petersburg, F 924 no. 561, ff. ob-1, 54a-60a.

121 *Jung-i Qāzī Mīr Sayyid Qamar Ṣudūr*, ms. IVANUz 2588, f. 22a. For a discussion of the original documents tucked away in Sayyid Qamar's *jung*, see Sanjar Gulamov, "O nekotorykh podlinnykh dokumentakh iz kollektsii al-Biruni", unpublished working paper, 2010.

including a lettrist analysis of its owner's name with the object of divining his past or future.¹²²

According to a method standard in the science of *jafr*, [the subject's name] QADYMYRSYDQMRBNQADYMYRSYD'ALM [i.e., Qāzī Mīr Sayyid Qamar b. Qāzī Mīr Sayyid 'Ālim] may be analyzed on the basis of five categories: personal name (*ism*), honorific (*laqab*), patronymic (*kunyat*), ascendant (*ṭālī'*) and ruler of the ascendant (*ṣāhib-i ṭālī'*). This method is as follows: taking these five categories, perform thereon the *taksīr* operation of *ṣudūr u mu'akkharāt*,¹²³ then contemplate...those words compounded by the lines produced—they surely indicate the past or future condition of the querent (*ṭālīb*), depending on whether they are in normal or reverse order (*manṣūb^{an} aw maqlūb^{an}*).¹²⁴

Moreover, astrological observations and geomantic readings appear to be just as common as lettrist operations, if not more so.¹²⁵

In short, Maḥmūd Khwāja's complaint about the contemporary neglect of *jafr* is to be understood primarily as a rhetorical device, one exceedingly common in the Persian epistolary tradition. (By the same token, authors routinely opened their works with protestations of their scholarly insufficiency for the task—which was nevertheless then accomplished with high polish.) That is not to say we should take lightly his condemnation of a group of local 'prayer-reciters' (*ṣalavāt-kh'ānān*), whose treasonous dalliance with the Russians, he charges, is threatening the realm and counteracting all his letter-magical efforts to preserve it. But the fact remains that a 19th-century Bukharan scholar like Maḥmūd Khwāja could report spending a 42-year career producing talismans on a daily basis precisely because there was sustained demand for such a high level of production.¹²⁶

122 *Jung-i Qāzī Mīr Sayyid Qamar Ṣudūr*, ff. 360a, 363b. See also *Jūng-i Masāyil u Vāqī'āt*, ms. IVANUZ 8887, f. oa.

123 I.e., the reordering of letters in a line produced by a *taksīr* operation by alternately taking letters from the beginning and end of that line. E.g.: ALFMYBNW → AWLNFBMY.

124 The rest of the passage expands on the point that reading *taksīr*-generated lines in the normal (*manṣūb*, i.e., right-to-left) order gives information about the querent's future, while reading them in reverse (*maqlūb*, i.e., left-to-right) order gives information about his or her past.

125 See e.g. *Jung-i Qāzī Mīr Sayyid Qamar Ṣudūr*, f. 133b; *Jūng-i Masāyil u Vāqī'āt*, f. 1a.

126 See letter below.

As *jung* texts attest in particular, moreover, occultists were hardly a professional class apart. Rather, they were ulama who mastered individual occult sciences according to personal inclination and scholarly preparation—and that always in tandem with many other forms of knowledge. Indeed, given their status as difficult—that is to say, elite—sciences, mastery of a range of more foundational disciplines, including Arabic grammar, tafsir, arithmetic, astronomy, agriculture, ethics, sufism and so on, was typically considered a prerequisite for the study of the occult sciences, routinely classed at the top of both epistemological and spiritual hierarchies. This point is well demonstrated in a *tazkirat* description of one ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Bukhārī, *takhalluṣ* Tamkīn, a particularly erudite teacher at the Dār al-Shifā’ madrasa in Bukhara¹²⁷ who went on to master lettrism, geomancy and astrology *after* completing the standard madrasa curriculum. Moreover, the biographer emphasizes the organic connection between sufism and occultism by stating that such a comprehensive mastery of the occult sciences is exclusive to the saints:

‘Abd al-Raḥmān Bukhārī, having fully mastered all the [standard] books [on various subjects] (*taḥṣīl u takhtīm-i kutub-rā karda*), applied the full power of his intellect to the most intricate fields of knowledge (*ma‘ārif-i juz’iyyāt*), this to the point that he claimed unrivalled mastery of the principles of lettrism (*jafr*), geomancy (*raml*) and astrology (*nujūm*) and singular knowledge of the principles of magic squares (*awfāq*) and geomantic figures (*ashkāl*), together with the three occult sciences (*‘ulūm-i salāsa-yi muḥayyabāt*) now known as *sīmiyā*, *rīmiyā* and *kīmiyā* [i.e., illusionism, terrestrial magic and alchemy]. Such a [bold] claim can only be made by one of the saints (*nabāshad juz bi dast-i awliyā*).¹²⁸

These details on Tamkīn’s occultist prowess, it should be noted, are included in a *poetical* anthology precisely as a clinching argument for his status as an outstanding High Persianate intellectual.

Maḥmūd Khwāja himself does not appear in these *tazkirats*, and so we cannot know what curriculum he followed together with his study of lettrism. But one Dāmlā Mīrak Jān A‘lam¹²⁹ (d. 1800), Maḥmūd Khwāja’s predecessor—and

127 This datapoint is provided in another biographical dictionary: Afzal Pirmastī Haravī, *Afzal al-Tazkār fī Zikr al-Shu‘arā’ va-l-Ash‘ār*, ms. IVANUz 2303, f. 55a. Pirmastī also confirms Tamkīn’s erudition in the occult sciences.

128 *Tazkirat al-Shu‘arā-i Muḥtaram*, f. 97a.

129 A‘lam was a scholarly rank in the Bukharan amirate. In some instances, at least, the *a‘lam* oversaw the activities of the muftis (Anke von Kügelgen, *Legitimatitsia sredneaziatskoi*

quite possibly his father—,¹³⁰ does appear therein, and so provides an instructive case for understanding the latter's environment and intellectual outlook. Mīrak Jān's biographer does not initially single him out as especially learned in the occult sciences (in contrast with the aforementioned Tamkīn), but rather as renowned for his ability to engage in disputations in Arabic on the finer points of Islamic doctrine; he is portrayed as going head-to-head with the greatest scholars of the realm even at a very young age:

In the majlises of the great Amir (*amīr-i kabīr*),¹³¹ [Mīrak Jān], despite his youth, debated (*munāẓara*) in Arabic with the greatest scholars [of the age], including Mawlavī Ākhund Jān and his peers—and he always won (*hamvāra ghālib mē-āyada*)!¹³²

Professionally, Mīrak Jān was appointed qadi and *raʿīs*¹³³ of Qarshi by the Manghit amir Sayyid Ḥaydar Tora (r. 1800-1827), one of Mīrak Jān's students, who was then serving as governor of the city.¹³⁴ Aside from his alleged descent from none other than Ismāʿīl b. Aḥmad I (r. 892-907), the first great Samanid monarch, Mīrak Jān's scholarly profile was not dissimilar to that of his peers: Islamic law, Arabic scripture, Persian poetry, sufism.

Beyond these already substantial talents, Mīrak Jān's biographer added another skill to the mix: *jafr*. But rather than identifying it as merely one more skill in the scholar's broad skillset, he posits it as the foundation of his entire scholarly persona:

dinastii mangitov v proizvedeniakh ikh istorikov, XVIII-XIX vv., Almaty, Daik-Press, 2004, p. 100).

130 See below.

131 I.e., Shāh Murād (r. 1785-1800), the third Manghit ruler.

132 Vāẓih, *Tuḥfat al-Aḥbāb*, f. 186.

133 By the 19th century, the position of *raʿīs* was synonymous with *muḥtasib* (censor, morality police) in Bukhara (Pickett, "The Persianate Sphere", p. 193).

134 Amir Ḥaydar was the father of Naṣr Allāh Manghit (r. 1827-60), who is obliquely referenced in Maḥmūd Khwāja's letter (see appendix). Thanks to training by the likes of Mīrak Jān, Ḥaydar was remembered as learned in the Islamic sciences. The Manghit dynasty had deep roots to the city of Qarshi, which they ruled as governors long before taking the Bukharan throne in 1747. On the rise of the Manghits, see in particular Andreas Wilde, *What Is Beyond the River? Power, Authority and Social Order in Eighteenth and Nineteenth-Century Transoxania*, Vienna, Verlag der Österreichischen Akademie der Wissenschaften (forthcoming).

It is reported that Dāmlā Mirak Jān's [vast] knowledge came not through study, but was rather the product of his period of training under a certain scholar in the science of *jafr*; he expended considerable effort in performing lettrist operations (*baṣṭ u taksīr u madākhl u makhārīj*) on the blessed [divine] name the All-knowing (*al-ʿalīm*), [a pursuit which rendered him preternaturally knowledgeable].¹³⁵

In other words, the secret to Mirak Jān's otherwise inexplicable success, his biographer avers, was his early and effective use of what may be called knowledge or memory magic—a close cognate to the technique known in Latin as *Ars notoria*,¹³⁶ though here presented as a strictly lettrist procedure, and specifically a form of divine-names magic.

Although this remarkable passage does not go on to specify whether it was Mīrak Jān's training in lettrism specifically that attracted the patronage of the Manghit amir of Bukhara, we do learn that it was much prized by his patron by the end of his career. Shortly before Amir Ḥaydar ascended the throne in 1800, the army of a rival dynasty in Qunduz invaded Ḥiṣār,¹³⁷ and Ḥaydar's father, Shāh Murād, dispatched him to defend Bukhara's claim on the territory.¹³⁸ Ḥaydar emerged from the conflict victorious—but only with the aid of Mirak Jān's mobilized letter magic:

[Sayyid Ḥaydar] having commanded the aforementioned scholar [Mīrak Jān] to perform a lettrist operation (*ʿamal-i jafr*), the latter accordingly constructed a 3 × 3 magic square (*ṣūrat*) with [the name of] Allāh Birdi¹³⁹

135 Vāziḥ, *Tuḥfat al-Aḥbāb*, f. 186.

136 On this and other European mnemotechnic traditions see Frances Yates, *The Art of Memory*, Chicago, University of Chicago Press, 1966.

137 Ḥiṣār was the regional center of the mountainous province encompassing what is now the capital of Tajikistan; Qunduz is a city now located in northern Afghanistan. On Ḥiṣār's history of autonomous rule, see Thomas Welsford, "Rethinking the Ḥamzahids of Ḥiṣār", *Asiatische Studien* 65 (2011), pp. 797–823.

138 The *tazkirat* in question characterizes this event as the rebellion (*tuḡhyān*) of a local governor, but chronicle sources reveal that it was in fact an invasion from across the Oxus by the rival Qataghan dynasty of Qunduz: Mīr Salmān Samarqandī, *Tafṣīl u Bayān-i Dawlat-i Jamāʿat-i Manghit az Zamān-i Raḥīm Khān*, ms. Sankt-Peterburgskii Filial Instituta Vostokovedenii (Rossiiskoi Akademii Nauk, Institut Vostochnykh Rukopisei) 667, ff. 163a–163b.

139 A noble of the Qataghan dynasty of Qunduz. Mirak Jān was trained by Muḥammad ʿAṭāʾ Allāh b. Hādī Khwāja (d. 1795) (Vāziḥ, *Tuḥfat al-Aḥbāb*, f. 186); this fact is confirmed in a hagiography devoted to ʿAṭāʾ Allāh: Abū l-Barakāt al-Mulaqqab bi Pādshāh-i ʿAzīz Khwāja

opening with the house of killing (*qatl*),¹⁴⁰ occupying himself with writing [this talisman] and all its related procedures. Upon completing the [process of] invocation (*kh^wāndan*) and writing, he then struck the [resulting] talisman (*ṣūrat*) with a sword (*shamshūr*)—and the aforementioned malefactor was killed there [in Ḥiṣār] the same day, nay, that very hour. The moment the scholar struck the talisman with a sword a goose (*kharbatī*) landed on his blessed shoulder.¹⁴¹

Mīrak Jān died shortly after this occultist feat, but some of his many students went on to become the most prominent scholars of their generation—certain of them doubtlessly carrying on the practice of *jafr* as well.¹⁴²

Intriguingly, the sources identify Mīrak Jān as the father of one Ēshān Maḥmūd Kh^wāja Aʿlam. It is unfortunate that we cannot match this individual to the author of the letter transcribed and translated in the appendix with any degree of certainty, as the chronicler merely lists this Maḥmūd Kh^wāja as one of the scholars ‘who were in Amir Muẓaffar’s cavalcade during the war with Russia’ in 1868.¹⁴³ As a fellow master of lettrism contemporary with

Mīrgānī Raẓavī, *Manāqib u Maqāmāt-i Sayyid Muḥammad ‘Aṭā’ Allāh Shaykh al-Islām*, ms. Rossiskaia Natsional’naia Biblioteka (Otdel Rukopisei, Sankt-Peterburg) P.n.s. 200, ff. 45a-45b. Intriguingly, Allāh Birdi Qataghan was *also* listed as one of ‘Aṭā’ Allāh’s disciples in that same hagiography: *ibid.*, f. 57b. For a broader discussion of Muḥammad ‘Aṭā’ Allāh b. Hādī Kh^wāja’s family dynasty, see James Pickett, “Nadir Shah’s Peculiar Central Asian Legacy: Empire, Conversion Narratives, and the Rise of New Scholarly Dynasties,” *IJMES* 48 (2016), pp. 491-510.

140 I.e., the eighth house.

141 Vāziḥ, *Tuḥfat al-Aḥbāb*, ff. 187-188. This event is corroborated with very similar wording in another biographical dictionary: ‘Abd Allāh Kh^wāja ‘Abdī, *Taẓkirat al-Shu‘arā-yi ‘Abd Allāh Kh^wāja ‘Abdī*, ms. IVANUz 64, ff. 164b-165a.

142 For instance, Ḥājji Muḥammad Ḥusayn Khan was a famous poet and scholar who was forcibly relocated to Bukhara after his father, the governor of Marv, was defeated by Shāh Murād Manghit in 1786. Vāziḥ reports that Ḥājji Muḥammad studied ‘certain of the abstruse sciences’ (*ba‘ẓi az ‘ulūm-i mushkila*)—here almost certainly meaning the occult sciences, often referred to as *‘ulūm-i ghāmiza*, with the same meaning—under Mīrak Jān in Bukhara until he managed to escape the region to Najaf (*Tuḥfat al-Aḥbāb*, f. 68). Another of his students, Abū Naṣr Tūghī, was exiled to the Ottoman Empire (Rūm) upon being accused of religious deviance (*az shāhrāh-i sharī‘at munḥarif shavad*), though the chronicler does not tie his transgression to any occultist practice (Sharif Jān Makhdūm Ṣadr Ẓiyā, *Navādir-i Ẓiyā’iyya*, ms. IVANUz 1304/11, f. 45).

143 Ēshān Maḥmūd Kh^wāja Aʿlam b. Dāmlā Mīrak Jān Aʿlam is listed under the heading *‘ulamā’ ki dar muḥāraba-yi Rūs bi rikāb-i Amīr Muẓaffar būdand* (*Navādir-i Ẓiyā’iyya*, f. 49a).

the petition's author, and like him an esteemed provider of military-magical support to the Manghit dynasty, it is highly tempting to postulate a father-son relationship between Mīrak Jān and Mullā Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja, but this relationship is probable rather than definite.¹⁴⁴

Even if no such connection actually obtained, however, the similarities between accounts from three very different literary genres—*munsha'āt*, *tazkirats* and *jungs*—support our contention that colonialism did not mark the stark rupture usually portrayed in the literature. Mīrak Jān deployed his occultist expertise to help his royal patron deal militarily with a rebellion at the turn of the 19th century in precisely the same way his earlier cognates throughout the Persianate world had been doing for centuries, as we have seen. In Maḥmūd Khwāja's time, the actors were different, but the science he proposed to exploit was in all features and applications identical: *jafr* would be now deployed to 'to subjugate the Russians and render them tributary', just as it had successfully subjugated Shahrīsabz and Ḥiṣār only decades prior—and just as Amir Temūr himself had 'pulverized' Russia by virtue of the 500 lettrists in his personal entourage.¹⁴⁵ For Maḥmūd Khwāja and his fellow ulama, heirs of a long occultist tradition studded with political-military and philosophical-scientific success, the challenges of colonialism rendered letter magic more apropos and attractive than ever.

Conclusion

On the basis of this case study, we have argued for the conscious continuity of High Persianate scholarly culture over half a millennium or more, a virtue that rendered it resilient during the half-century of Russian occupation (1868-1920).¹⁴⁶ It was only after this point that aggressive Soviet social reengineering, predicated on an identification of occultism and sufism with superstition on the one hand and Islam with literalist, doctrinaire scripturalism on the other, finally succeeded in forcing a rupture within Central Asian

144 Furthermore, with approximately 80 years separating Mīrak Jān's death from Maḥmūd Khwāja's letter, the former would have to have been rather spry in his later years, and the former rather elderly at the time of writing, for the chronology to work. Another possibility is that the two were separated by a generation, or that Mīrak Jān's biographer (writing nearly a century later) was mistaken about his death date.

145 See letter below.

146 For a wider-angle analysis of the same question see Mana Kia, *Sensibilities of Belonging: Transregional Persianate Community before Nationalism* (forthcoming).

Persianate society. Soviet policy was exceedingly strategic, and perceptive, in this regard: occultism, like sufism or poetry, was a core component of High Persianate culture, crucial to the cosmopolitan whole; it therefore merited an extra measure of marginalization within the larger Soviet project of *divide et impera*. With great epistemic violence, the High Persianate-Islamicate culture of Central Asia was thus flensed and dismembered, and select, neutered elements reassigned to newly formalized ethnic groupings. Tajik, Kazakh, Kyrgyz, Turkmen—all were made to stumble separately, clutching a brittle Islam; their letter-mage defenders were overpowered by imperial onslaught. Yet the Soviet transformation of occultism into superstition and Islam into scripturalism was a powerful act of sorcery in its own right—one that continues to enthrall the Central Asian religious-scholarly classes, who are reflexively dismissive of their own intellectual-spiritual patrimony despite its shadowy persistence in living memory. High occultism has magically become the low witchery of the uneducated.¹⁴⁷

These later developments aside, however, how are we to conceptualize the relationship of High Persianate cultural continuity to European colonialism? There can be no question here of “modern”, progressive, intellectually weaned Russians or Soviets—or, for that matter, Jadid reformists—triumphing over “unmodern”, static, intellectually unweaned Muslims. Bruno Latour, Michael Taussig, Mark Schneider and others have conclusively exposed the illusory—and hence profoundly magical—nature of this thing called *modernity*, typically wielded as a bludgeon to otherize non-Euro-Americans by force or to keep non-elites in check;¹⁴⁸ and Wouter Hanegraaff, Jeffrey Kripal, Christopher Bracken and others have shown the essential modernity, and postmodernity, of the “savage philosophy” that is occultism—the primary Other upon whose undead frame post-Enlightenment Western culture, high and low, has been constructed.¹⁴⁹ Nor does time move faster for the colonizer and slower for the colonized.¹⁵⁰ His vivid invocation of 14th- or 17th-century imperial glories and

147 Cf. Styers, *Making Magic*, pp. 208–210 (“Magic and Colonial Control”).

148 Bruno Latour, *On the Modern Cult of the Factish Gods*, Durham, Duke UP, 2010; *idem*, *We Have Never Been Modern*, trans. Catherine Porter, Cambridge, Mass., Harvard UP, 1993; Michael Taussig, *The Magic of the State*, New York, Routledge, 1997; Mark A. Schneider, *Culture and Enchantment*, Chicago, University of Chicago Press, 1993.

149 Hanegraaff, *Esotericism and the Academy*; Jeffrey J. Kripal, *Authors of the Impossible: The Paranormal and the Sacred*, Chicago, University of Chicago Press, 2010; Christopher Bracken, *Magical Criticism: The Recourse of Savage Philosophy*, Chicago, Chicago UP, 2007 (our thanks to Nicholas Harris for the latter reference).

150 I.e., the “denial of coevalness” posited by Johannes Fabian (*Time and the Other: How Anthropology Makes Its Object*, New York, Columbia UP, 1983); postcolonial theorizing

fierce commitment to a canonical Islamic occultist tradition notwithstanding, Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja was a man of the late 19th century to no degree less than were his Russian foes; his temporal frame of reference was simply different—the High Persianate. This is not even to mention the strikingly similar ubiquity over centuries of high and low occultist traditions in Russia as well, a discomfiting reality usually quietly ignored in the literature: early modern Russian imperialism was on occasion as thoroughlygoingly occultist as its earlier and contemporary cognates in the Islamicate-Persianate world, to say nothing of western Europe.¹⁵¹ Yet even so, how can continuity avoid charges of stasis, even stagnation? Is “cultural continuity” simply a polite, if condescending, euphemism for traditionalist natives’ penchant for living in cyclical, not linear, time, for stumbling backward into the future?

To the contrary, we suggest that cultural continuity, as a concept, implies the following traits: sustainability, flexibility, adaptability, pragmatism. These alone are the virtues that empowered the ulama of the Persianate world—an elite, cosmopolitan, autonomous and highly mobile social class—to act as sole gatekeepers of Islamicate culture and primary political counterweight to Turkic or Turko-Mongol rulers for a full millennium.¹⁵² Indeed, the power and prestige wielded by the scholarly elites of the precolonial Islamicate world is historically almost unrivalled—whence essentializing treatments of Islam as the religion of scholars and merchants *par excellence*. And as we have seen, a

must therefore devote itself to the “denial of the denial of coevalness” (Walter Mignolo, *The Darker Side of the Renaissance: Literacy, Territoriality, and Colonization*, 2nd ed., Ann Arbor, University of Michigan Press, 2003, pp. xi-xii). Our thanks to Joshua Grace for these references.

- 151 On occultism in both tsarist and Soviet Russia, see W. F. Ryan’s magisterial *The Bathhouse at Midnight: An Historical Survey of Magic and Divination in Russia*, University Park, Pennsylvania State UP, 1999 (focusing primarily on popular, rather than religious-scholarly, magical practices and beliefs); and *The Occult in Russian and Soviet Culture*, ed. Bernice Glatzer Rosenthal, Ithaca, Cornell UP, 1997. Problematising Ryan’s emphasis on low or folk occultism in particular, Robert Collis has recently shown that high occultist traditions like astrology and alchemy, some of them imported from western Europe, were a significant component of the Davidic millenarianism that drove the sweeping reform project of Peter the Great (r. 1682-1725) (*The Petrine Instauration: Religion, Esotericism and Science at the Court of Peter the Great, 1689-1725*, Leiden, Brill, 2012, pp. 460-522)—which is thus highly reminiscent of “early modern” Islamicate-Persianate forms of imperialism, whether Ottoman, Safavid or Mughal, also heavily shaped by scholar-occultists.
- 152 On the enduring, symbiotic relationship between the Turkic military elite and ulama in Central Asia, see e.g. Robert D. McChesney, “Central Asia’s Place in the Middle East: Some Historical Considerations”, in *Central Asia Meets the Middle East*, ed. David Menashri, London, Frank Cass, 1998, pp. 25-51.

significant and influential percentage of these scholarly elites rendered their services to ruling elites as professional occultists, offering solutions to the routine political, military, economic and medical problems faced by every dynasty in the course of rule. In other words, scholar-occultists like Maḥmūd Khwāja are perhaps better thought of as the *engineers* of High Persianate culture, in the most basic sense of that term: problem-solvers, exceedingly practical and constructive. That their tools of choice often included sciences like astrology, alchemy, geomancy or lettrism, this in addition to tafsir, jurisprudence, poetry and sufism, should not distract us from their basic function as builders and maintainers of society. (It is suggestive here that Arabic and Persian encyclopedists often classify mechanical engineering (*‘ilm al-ḥiyāl*) among the occult sciences.¹⁵³) Their success in this project is a matter of historical record: the ulama, adaptive and accommodating, managed to maintain a formally distinctive High Persianate-Islamicate culture over the vast spread of the Persian cosmopolis, from the Balkans and Anatolia in the west to Central Asia and India in the east, for over half a millennium. Remarkably, it persists to this day in the Islamic Republic of Iran, though in a guise less overtly occultist than was once the norm.¹⁵⁴

The present case study has shown lettrism in particular to be very much a going concern among Central Asian ulama-engineers through the end of the 19th century, with letter mages being routinely tapped by rulers for military service—the first line of defense against the Russian incursion and lesser threats. Our focus here has been on the city-state of Bukhara under Manghit rule; but instances of occultism being pitted against colonialism can easily be multiplied. Neighboring Afghan rulers, for example, corresponded with

153 See e.g. the seminal Persian encyclopedia of Shams al-Dīn Muḥammad Āmulī (d. 1352), *Nafāyis al-Funūn fī ‘Arāyis al-‘Uyūn*, wherein *ḥiyāl* is classified as an applied mathematical science, and defined as encompassing the production of wondrous (*gharīb*) movements and the construction of automata, hydraulics (*naql-i miyāh*), mechanics (*jarr-i aṣqāl*) and war machines (*ālāt-i ḥurūb*) (ed. Abū l-Ḥasan Sha‘rānī and Ibrāhīm Miyānjī, 3 vols., 3rd ed., Tehran, Intishārāt-i Islāmiyya, 1389 Sh./2010, vol. 3, p. 557). Two centuries later, the Ottoman encyclopedist Taşköprüzade (d. 1561) defined it in his Arabic *Miftāḥ al-Sa‘āda wa-l-Miṣbāḥ al-Siyāda* as a subset of the ‘science of concealment’ (*‘ilm al-ikhfā’*), predicated on ‘the ability to hide things present from onlookers, which is [termed] ingenious trickery (*ḥiyāl*)’ (3 vols., Beirut, Dār al-Kutub al-‘Ilmiyya, 1985, p. 346).

154 Cf. Iranian opposition candidate Mir Hossein Mousavi’s deriding of Mahmoud Ahmadinejad’s government as one of *kaf-bīnī u rammālī*, or palmistry and geomancing, in 2009 (Doostdar, “Fantasies of Reason”, p. 48, n. 19).

Turkestan astrologers in a bid to ward off colonial domination;¹⁵⁵ to the west, in Iran, Faṭḥ-ʿAlī Shāh Qajar (r. 1797-1834) drafted talismanists to drive out Russian invaders.¹⁵⁶ Farther afield, in Morocco, Mawlāy al-Ḥasan I (r. 1873-94) took up rigorous study of alchemy with the express intent of transforming the French into fish and casting them out to sea.¹⁵⁷

Due to the near-total neglect of occultism as a field of research into the evolution of Islamicate societies, however, such examples are typically cited, when they are acknowledged at all, only in passing: mere curiosities for the Wunderkammer that is Moslem unmodernity. But as has here been shown, occultism is crucial for understanding the nature of Islamicate continuities and discontinuities during the colonial period, from North, West and East Africa to Central, South and Southeast Asia, and even to North America.¹⁵⁸ Current anthropological research has made great strides in rehabilitating this category as an object of analysis for African, South American, Caribbean and other contexts, yet even so the focus is typically on the resilience of indigenous cultures and their magical subversions of high colonial modernity (which, of course, is a magical working in its own right).¹⁵⁹ In the Islamicate world, by contrast, it is *high occultism* that held pride of place as a primary engine of

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- 155 The emphasis on “Muhammadan” victory in this British colonial report is suggestive of concerns similar to those of Maḥmūd Khwāja: “On the 18th instant I learnt that a certain astrologer had written to the Amir from Turkistan to the effect:—‘Nauroz is drawing near. According to the Muhammadan system of astrological calculations there will be wars amongst great kings in the ensuing year, but that the Muhammadans will come out victorious, and that the party, whom the Amir will assist, will triumph. White dress should be worn by all on the day of the Nauroz’” (National Archive of India, Foreign Department, nos. 258-266: News-letters from the British Agent at Kabul, nos. 16 to 23 of 1884, “Translation of a letter from Lieutenant-Colonel Sardar Muhammad Afzal Khan, C. S. I. British Agent at Kabul, to the Secretary to the Government of India, Foreign Department, no. 22, dated Kabul, the 18th March 1884”, f. 2). In stark contrast, cf. an astrological text from the same file as that including Maḥmūd Khwāja’s letter predicting war and slaughter from the European advance into Afghanistan (TsGARUz F i-126 (“Qushbegi Fond”) O 1 D 1978, f. 5).
- 156 Jalāl al-Dīn Humāī, intro. to his edition of Ibn Sīnā, *Kunūz al-Muʿazzimīn*, p. 12 n. 2.
- 157 Georges Salmon, “Note sur l’alchimie à Fès”, *Archives Marocaines* 7 (1906), p. 452 (our thanks to Nicholas Harris for this reference).
- 158 Here the example of the Moorish Science Temple, founded in Newark, New Jersey, in 1913 by the Noble Drew Ali (d. 1929), is particularly striking; see Peter Lamborn Wilson, *Sacred Drift: Essays on the Margins of Islam*, San Francisco, City Lights Books, 1993, pp. 14-50.
- 159 See e.g. Michael Taussig, *Magic, Colonialism, and the Wild Man: A Study in Terror and Healing*, Chicago, University of Chicago Press, 1987; Peter Geschiere, *The Modernity of Witchcraft: Politics and the Occult in Postcolonial Africa*, trans. Peter Geschiere and Janet Roitman, Charlottesville, University Press of Virginia, 1997.

imperial glory and intellectual advance, this as wielded by ulama-engineers in service of religion and state. Unlike the “low” or popular forms of occultism typically dismissed as hedge magic, folk cunning and the like, endemic in pre-modern agrarian societies, this high occult-scientific tradition simply cannot be understood, and therefore evaluated on its own merits, without a familiarity with the entirety of Islamicate intellectual and cultural history.¹⁶⁰

To date, and predictably enough, the only context in which high occultist traditions have been rehabilitated is the European and Euro-American: the occult sciences are now largely accepted as an integral part of history of philosophy and history of science—primarily because they helped give rise to scientific modernity (which, again, is an illusory category).¹⁶¹ The same frameworks of analysis must now be extended to Islamicate culture generally and High Persianate culture specifically, which despite political, climatic, economic and biological upheavals was considerably more stable, more expansive and more occultist than its Christianate-Latinate counterpart throughout the so-called early modern period. Indeed, such a research plan would provide a much-needed control for the study of European “early modernity”; it is precisely the fact that the occult sciences did not give birth to “real” science in the Islamicate context that allows us to study them in their historical sociopolitical and intellectual settings without fear of falling into the honeyed trap of teleology.

As matters stand, most of the basic spadework that would make such comparative study possible has yet to be done. This article is a case in point: it is the first study of occultism in 19th-century Central Asia that does not presuppose its status as superstition, that recognizes its important role in sustaining High Persianate culture over centuries and adapting it to new colonial realities. And Maḥmūd Khwāja’s letter is in no way unique: the archives of Tashkent are flush

160 See e.g. the early 20th-century surveys of Persian folklore by Henri Massé (*Persian Beliefs and Customs*, trans. Charles Messner, New Haven, Human Relations Area Files, 1954) and Bess Allen Donaldson (*The Wild Rue: A Study of Muhammadan Magic and Folklore in Iran*, London, Luzac, 1938), which are largely incognizant of more elite, scholarly forms of occultist practice. This is not to suggest that high and low forms of occultism were not interactive; James Grehan has recently emphasized, for example, the essentially popular and syncretic nature of agrarian religious magic in late Ottoman Syro-Palestine, while also noting the dependency of illiterate peasants on lettered religious officials for the construction of talismans (*Twilight of the Saints: Everyday Religion in Ottoman Syria and Palestine*, Oxford, Oxford UP, 2014).

161 Many contemporary researchers are painfully aware of this bind, teleology continuing to drive legitimacy despite their best efforts; for the most incisive critique to date see Hanegraaff, *Esotericism and the Academy*.

with documents of a similar type,¹⁶² not to mention the many *jungs* featuring margins crammed with geomantic readings, astrological predictions or lettrist operations. The Al-Biruni Institute of Oriental Studies in particular is home to a rich manuscript collection preserving many of the prized occultist treatises and manuals on which scholars such as Maḥmūd Khwāja relied.¹⁶³ We therefore propose this study as a modest and preliminary model for the study of Central Asian occultism, a call to plumb the archival riches that testify to a still vigorous High Persianate culture during the first half-century of Russian colonialism.

In sum: Magic and modernity must no longer be treated as a binary in the study of Islamicate societies, an analytical posture distinctly untenable in light of current anthropological and critical theory. The framework must rather be one of multiple temporalities, both within and between cultures, the question one of continuities and ruptures: for high cultures, like great rivers, flow powerfully and are changed in the flowing, but may finally be dammed, drowning the cities they fed. To dammingly demodernize the occult—à la the Soviet ethnographers and orientalist of almost a century ago—is to occultly colonize it and its host cultures, is to cast a strong spell indeed.

Translation

Letter from Mullā Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja to the Ruler of Bukhara, Sayyid and Shadow of God (*ẓill Allāh*) [on Earth]:¹⁶⁴

The most abject Mullā Sayyid Maḥmūd Khwāja hereby offers his inherited and longstanding service of prayer for that most gracious eminence, the Shadow of God [on Earth] (God preserve him), in the hope that it will be magnanimously received. It is been 42 years since this willing servant spent three years in residence at the shrine of your ancestor, the Lion of God (*shīr-i khudā*),

162 Again, these “astrological” documents (which include texts promoting lettrism such as the one examined in this article, as well as others dealing with various occult sciences) are collected in TsGARUz F i-126 (“Qushbegi Fond”) O 1 D 1978; but other occultist texts not captured by Soviet archivists may well be scattered throughout this understudied repository, or simply lost in the chaos of revolution. To be clear, the preponderance of documents in this collection relate to revenue collection and land grants, not occult sciences—just like most collections of state documents.

163 Some of these have been referenced above. The late Khivan rulers’ fascination with Ps.-Būnī’s grimoire stands as a particularly intriguing avenue of inquiry.

164 Based on the historical references that follow, the addressee of this letter can only be Amir Muẓaffar Manghit (r. 1860–1885), whose reign spanned the Russian conquest (1868). See TsGARUz F i-126 (“Qushbegi Fond”) O 1 D 1978, f. 20.

in Balkh,¹⁶⁵ where with extreme exertion I acquired somewhat of the science of *jafr*¹⁶⁶—the radiance of Oneness (*nūr-i vaḥdat*) and part of the Prophetic legacy, a practice peculiar to your ancestor, the Lion of God, and staple technique (*dastūr al-ʿamal*) among the members of the House [of the Prophet]. Having occupied myself with this noble discipline down to the present moment, then, during this [42-year] period I achieved four [notable] results:

- 1) The first [was achieved] during the lifetime of your departed father: I began just such a [*jafrī*] operation in support of conquest and victory on the same day that he set out to take Shahrīsabz (to wit, the 15th of Shaʿbān), and on the 45th [and final] day of this operation he succeeded in taking the city.¹⁶⁷
- 2) Confronted with invasion and conquest by the accursed Russians (*Ūrūs-i laʿīn*), I was instructed via a quranic bibliomantic consultation (*istikhāra*)¹⁶⁸ to perform three [*jafrī*] cycles (*niṣāb*), each taking 45 days to complete; as a result, they were unable to advance beyond Samarkand and Katta-Qurghan.¹⁶⁹
- 3) When your esteemed departed grandfather fell sick in Gala-āsyā,¹⁷⁰ he came to me and requested [my help]. I accordingly wrote 38 lettrist talismans for healing (*lawḥ-i shifā-yi jafrī*) and sent them by way of Qāzī Ṣadr

165 I.e., the *mazār-i sharīf* or tomb of ʿAlī b. Abī Ṭālib in Balkh, subject of a monograph-length study: McChesney, *Waqf in Central Asia*.

166 See n. 1 above.

167 The city-state of Shahrīsabz, a primary competitor with Bukhara, enjoyed an uninterrupted line of succession under the Keneges dynasty from 1759 until 1858, when Naṣr Allāh Khan Manghit finally marched into the city after ten years of constant warfare. The tenure of Manghit governors in Shahrīsabz was short-lived, however, as a local uprising soon restored Keneges rulers to power until 1870, when Russia decisively subjected Shahrīsabz and assigned its governance to Bukhara. The Bukharan conquest of Shahrīsabz proved an even more challenging feat than Naṣr Allāh's better-known occupation of Khoqand in 1842.

168 I.e., bibliomancy (lit., 'seeking guidance'). On this practice in the early modern Safavid context, see Christiane Gruber, "The 'Restored' Shīʿī *muṣḥaf* as Divine Guide? The Practice of *fāl-i Qurʾān* in the Ṣafavid Period", *Journal of Qurʾanic Studies*, 13/2 (2011), pp. 29–55.

169 Interestingly, it was in fact a counterattack on Samarkand by again-independent Shahrīsabz that prompted Konstantin von Kaufman (Governor General of Russian Turkestan, 1867–1882) to cut short his assault on Bukhara after taking the frontier outpost of Katta-Qurghan (A. M. Malikov, "The Russian Conquest of the Bukharan Emirate: Military and Diplomatic Aspects", *Central Asian Survey* 33/2 (2014), pp. 192–193).

170 A village near Bukhara (modern spelling: Galaosiyo).

al-Dīn;¹⁷¹ having dissolved them [in water], he drank [them] and was healed the same day.

- 4) With evil intent six thousand Russians occupied Jām; I was instructed via a bibliomantic consultation to write [a talisman], and on the 40th day of the operation they decamped.¹⁷²

O servant-succoring, world-sheltering lord, for 42 years and up to the present moment I have every day written [talismans] to protect the health and happiness of the realm (*mulk*) and to ward off ill fortune (*nuḥūsat*). I had no patron (*murabbī*) to support me or provide me with paper and pen, [but] according to the dictum *He who is commanded is excused* (*al-ma'mūr ma'zūr*), I [nevertheless] occupied myself with this work. And had my teacher (*murshid*) allowed me to cease practicing it, these most satisfying results could not have been achieved. [Such work appears to me to be all the more pressing now], for today it has been three years since I personally heard from a member of a group of prayer-reciters (*ṣalavāt-kh'wānān*)¹⁷³ that, laughing together, [his treasonous fellows] said [to him]: "Friend, this sum of money is nothing—what good is it to us? Go ask the Russians for more!" From that moment to this I have written [talismans daily] with a heavy heart.

I therefore submit [to your eminence]: It is recorded in books on the principles of *jafr* that from the time of the dawning of the light of *jafr*—the holy Imam Ja'far Ṣādiq having made it known 70 years after the Hijra by command of your

171 Ṣadr al-Dīn came from a family dynasty of ulama that held the post of *qāzī-yi kalān* ('chief judge', used interchangeably with the more standard term *qāzī l-quḏāt*) for three generations. The family hailed from the region of Kulāb and migrated to Bukhara in the wake of the Russian conquest, which secured imperial control of Bukhara's mountainous frontier region (Stéphane A. Dudoignon, "Faction Struggles among the Bukharan Ulama during the Colonial, the Revolutionary and the Early Soviet Periods (1826-1929): A Paradigm for History Writing?", in *Muslim Societies: Historical and Comparative Aspects*, ed. Sato Tsugitaka, London, RoutledgeCurzon, 2004, p. 74).

172 Here Maḥmūd Kh'wāja is taking credit for the undoing of the ill-fated *Jamskii otriad* (Jam force), a military expedition that featured prominently in the Russo-Turkish war of 1877-1878. This expeditionary force of over 12,000 men was conceived as one of the very few maneuvers actually intended to spark fears of Russian encroachment on British India, but the tsarist government soon balked, and the expedition was abandoned in August of 1878 after scores of soldiers had died of disease. Russian troops never clashed with local forces, as Bukhara was by then firmly under colonial protection (Morrison, "Beyond the 'Great Game'").

173 This term, along with *maqṣūra-kh'wān*, refers in Central Asian waqfs to students with endowment stipends received in exchange for continually reciting sections of the Qur'an (our thanks to Nasriddin Mirzoev of the Uzbek State Archive for this clarification).

forebear (*jaddatān*) the holy Lion of God, a fact indicated by his very name: remove the ‘ from Ja‘far (*JFR*) and within it is revealed the word *jafr* (*JFR*)— from the time of Imam Ja‘far Ṣādiq, then, to that of your forebear¹⁷⁴ Sayyid Subhān Qulī Khan,¹⁷⁵ all emperors (*pādishān*), notables (*akābirān*), shaykhs (*mashāyikh*), scholars (*‘ulamā*) and scribes (*ahl-i khaṭṭ*) have, without exception, been devoted to *jafr* (*hama jafrī būdand*). Your own forefather (*bābātān*) Amir Temür himself personally employed 500 specialists in the science; for this reason he was able to conquer Anatolia twice with [only] 12 Uzbek detachments and pulverize (*mayda karda*) the Russians such that they became his willing servants, and [ultimately] to subjugate five climes. And your forebear Sayyid Subhān Qulī Khan personally employed 45 scribes tasked with writing [talismans], such that ambassadors (*ilchī*) from the seven climes would come to pay their respects at his exalted citadel (*arg-i ‘ālī*) and seek his help.

But [his successor] Abū l-Fayz Khan¹⁷⁶ neglected this science. He was nevertheless forced to have recourse to the *jafr* specialists he had abandoned, this after advancing into deserts [to no purpose]; he [repented of his folly] and restored those dismissed (*raj‘at*),¹⁷⁷ then proceeded to triumph by means of an army of the unseen (*lashkar-i ghayb*). [In short], *jafr* alone elevated him to the lordship (*murabbī*) of Bukhara, which he then rendered to Nādir [Shāh].¹⁷⁸ This restoration is still in effect.

174 Here Maḥmūd Khwāja again uses the term *jaddatān* (lit. “your grandfather”) to refer to members of a patrilineally unrelated dynasty (likewise, the subsequent *bābātān* [lit. “your father”] to refer to Amir Temür). It is possible that the author had in mind the Manghits’ intermarriage into these other dynasties. But since none of the later Manghits referred to this marriage into the Tuqay-Timurid line as a legitimating factor (Wilde, “What is Beyond the River?”, p. 503), it seems more likely that the author was invoking metaphorical continuity to buttress his case for long-term *occultist* continuity.

175 On Subhān Qulī Khan (r. 1681-1702) as philosopher-king see László Károly, ed. and tr., *A Turkic Medical Treatise from Islamic Central Asia: A Critical Edition of a Seventeenth-Century Chaghatay Work by Subhān Qulī Khan*, Leiden, Brill, 2015.

176 R. 1711-1747.

177 *Raj‘a* is a technical term in Islamic law denoting a man’s remarriage his divorced wife, the concept referenced rhetorically here.

178 Nādir Shāh (r. 1736-1747) elevated Abū l-Fayz Khan to the throne in exchange for submission. In the original document, however, the word in question (Nādir) falls on a crease and is quite unclear, and is not accompanied by any of the qualifiers one would expect; but even if our reading here is incorrect, the history being recounted here was still very much bound up with Nādir Shāh’s invasion, and so the general meaning still obtains. For a corrective to Nādir Shāh’s often neglected place in Central Asian history, see James Pickett, “Nadir Shah’s Peculiar Central Asian Legacy.”

[However], the evil designs (*niyyat-i bad*) of [the aforementioned] prayer-reciters have been pursued with such resolve that this poor [servant] has been unable to produce any good results [during the last three years]. Therefore I, your old servant, humbly hope and ask that you revive the tradition of your forefathers (*sunnat-i ābā u ajdād*) and order that 44 persons be found who can teach *jafr*, making 45 with the addition of this ignorant servant; if they [together] write a full cycle every day¹⁷⁹ to remove the property of ill fortune [from your prospects], you will be able to subjugate the Russians and render them tributary, and ambassadors will come to pay their respects and seek help at your exalted citadel as of old.

Your exalted essence having been preserved by divine blessing, may perpetual prosperity, gladness of heart and firmness of mind render your noble days felicitous. I humbly submit that while such temerity on my part is indeed the height of bad manners, it nevertheless constitutes a dispatch from the spiritual realm (*‘ālam-i rūḥāniyyat*) wherein dwell the guardians (*muḥakkalāt*) of this noble [science of] *jafr*—besides which, the ant cannot possibly impose upon Solomon!¹⁸⁰

O God, protect this amir from all calamities and allow him to realize his every purpose; subjugate his enemies and give him rule over the seven climes, this by virtue of the sanctity of the Prophet of mercy (*nabī l-raḥma*)¹⁸¹ and that of his House and his Companions. O just amir, we crave of your magnanimity and mercies the pardoning of faults.

Marginal addendum: I humbly submit that these proposals will be found reasonable by his eminence the Shadow of God such that he give command [that they be enacted. To this end], I trust that he will dispatch a member of his noble retinue—someone receptive of secrets and possessed of resolute vision—to this wretch so I may communicate the specifics of this matter to his eminence. I acknowledge all faults!

179 A full cycle taking one person 45 days to complete, and 45 persons one day.

180 Cor 27, 15-19.

181 The letter has here *al-nabī al-raḥma*, evidently a typo.

Transcription¹⁸²

مکتوب از ملا سید محمود خواجه به سید ظلّ الله حاکم بخارا

// حضرت شیر خدا رضی الله تعالی عنه

// حضرت ظلّ الله سلمه الله تعالی

// سید سبحانقلی خان¹⁸³

عرض بنده گی دعاگوی موروثی ملا سید محمود خواجه افقر بجناب مستطاب / حضرت ظلّ الله سلمه الله تعالی / بامید قبول و کرم اینکه بنده نوازا مدتّ چهل دو سال شد که در بلخ در سر مزار جدّتان / حضرت شیر خدا رضی الله تعالی عنه / سه سال استقامت نموده بریاضت بسیار نبذی از علم جفر، که نور وحدت و آثار نبوت است و عمل جدّتان / حضرت شیر خدا رضی الله تعالی عنه / و دستور العمل اهل بیت بود است، بدست در آورده، آمده تا ایندم باینعمل شریف ملازمت دارم. درینمدّت چهار نتیجه حاصل شد :

اول در زمان باباتان مرحومی، و آن اینست که پانزده شعبان از برای فتح شهر سبز سوار شدند، همان روز اینعمل را از برای فتح و نصرت سر کردم؛ روز چهل و پنجم عمل شهر سبز فتح شد. دوم بعد از استیلا و غلبه اوروں لعین باستخاره مأمور شده، سه نصاب که هر نصاب چهل و پنج روز است نوشتم؛ از ثمر قند و کته قورغا نگذشت. سیوم جناب جدّتان مرحومی خردی از گله آسیا کسل شیده آمدند، بامرشان و بوساطت قاضی صدر الدین سی و هشت لوح شفاء جفّری نوشته دادم؛ حلّ نموده نوشیدند شفا روزشان شد. چهارم ست هزار اوروں بموضع جام آمده به تبت فاسد استقامت نمود؛ [باستخاره] مأمور شده نوشتم؛ روز چهلم عمل فترات شد.

بنده نوازا مولاها جهان پناها مدتّ چهل دو سال است که تا الحال هر روزه از آسایش ملک و سلامتی شان و رفع نحوست مینویسم. مربّی ندارم که از حام خبر گرفته بلب نائی و بیک تحتّه

182 We are indebted to Akmal Bazarbaev of the Uzbek State Archive and Institute of History of Uzbekistan for his assistance in deciphering certain obscure passages in this document. While we have inserted minimal punctuation into the text, we have not otherwise altered the original orthography, which is occasionally idiosyncratic or specific to Central Asian usage (e.g., *Ūrūs*, *Šamarqand*, *Katta-Qirghā*, *pul*, *pādishān*, *akābirān*, *iltifāt*, etc.).

183 These three names are written above the main body of the letter, which uses double slash marks to indicate where they should be inserted.

کاغذی مرا دستگیری نماید، بحکم (المأمور معذور) باینعمل مشغولم. باین عمل از مرشد خود مرخص میباشم ترک کرده نمیتوانم چندانی نتیجه دل آرام مییافته گی نمیشود. ظاهراً حمل [همه باین] میکم که روزی سه سال شد که بگو شم از زبان بعضی صلوٰه خوانان شنیدم که بیکدیگر خندها کرده میگویند که: «ای جوره این قدر پل مُفت بمایان بکجا بود. اوروس را دعا کید که بیشتر آید.» از آن وقت تا ایندم دل سیاهانه قلم میرانم.

عرض بنده گی دیگر اینکه در کتابهای اصول جفر سمت مستور است که از زمان ظهور نور جفر که بامر و اشاره جدّاتان / حضرت شیر خدا رضی الله تعالی عنه / حضرت امام جعفر صادق بعد از هفتاد سال از هجرت جفر را آشکارا نمودند، چنانچه نام شان که جعفر است مشعر باین معنی است، زیرا که عین بیفتاد است در درون لفظ جفر در آید جعفر میشود. و از زمان امام جعفر صادق تا زمان جدّاتان / سید سبحانقلی خان / همه پادشان و اکابران و مشایخ و علما و اهل خط همه جفری بودند. و امیر تیمور باباتان پانصد کس جفری مأمور نوشتن بودند؛ بنابراین بدوازده لشکر اوزبکیه¹⁸⁴ روم را دو بار فتح نمودند، و اوروس را میده کرده بخود غلام نمودند، و پنج اقلیم مسخرشان شد. و سید سبحانقلی خان جدّاتان چهل پنج اهل قلم مأمور نوشتن بودند تا که از هفت اقلیم ایلچی آمده آستانه ارک عالی را بوسه داده استمداد مینمودند. ابو الفیض خان باین عمل القاطن کردند؛ لا علاج اصحاب جفر ترک نموده برآمده بصحراها امام شدند. رجعت نموده تا درآمده استیلا یافت بلشکر غیب که بسبب نوشتن جفر مرتبی بخارا بودند [نادر] را جزا دادند، و آن رجعت هنوز است.

تیت بد صلوٰه خوانان ضمّ شده عمل من بیچاره چندانی نتیجه نمیدهد. من پیر غلام تصدّق شوم، امید میکم که سنت آبا و اجداد خود را احیا نموده امر نمایند که چهل چار کس یافته باین تعلیم جفر نموده، هر کدام مع اینغلام نادان چهل پنج کس شده، هر روزی یکصبا بی نویسند از روی خاصیت نحوست برداشته شده اوروس مطیع و مسخر شده از هفت اقلیم مثل قدیم ایلچی آمده آستانه ارک عالی بوسه داده استمداد جویند.

ذات عالی با برکات محفوظ و مصون بوده بکامرانی دایمی و بخوش دلی و خاطر جمعی روزگار شریف میسر گردد. تصدّق شوم اینهمه جرئت از من کمال بد ادبی است، اما از عالم روحانیت که موکلات جفر شریف میباشند اشارتی و بشارتی است؛ دگر نه مور را چه جرئت است که بسوی سلیمان وقت اینهمه گستاخی نماید.

184 The number 118 is written below *lashkar*.

اللهم احفظ هذا الامير عن جميع الآفات؛ حصل له كل مقاصده وقهر جميع اعداءه و سلطه على
سبعة الافاليم¹⁸⁵ بحرمات النبي الرحمة¹⁸⁶ وآله واصحابه. ايها الامير العادل نرجو من عطاءك و
مراحمك عفو التقصيرات و محو السيئات.

هامش:

تصدق شوم عرضها معقول جناب ظلّ اللهی شده امر نمایند؛ امید می‌کیم که کسی از اهل صحبت
شریف کدام که قابل اسرار و دیده محکم باشد سپارش عالی را بمن بیچاره و خصوصیات این امر را
از من بجنابشان رساند. التقصير التقصير التقصير.

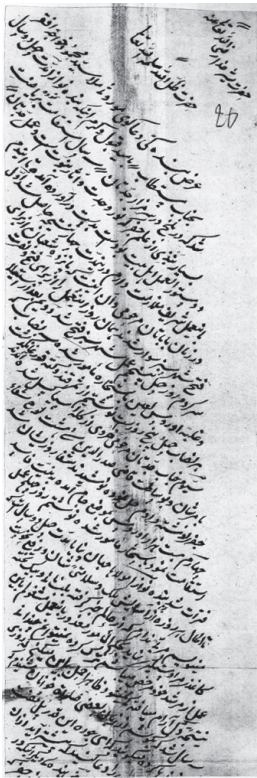


PLATE 1

TsGARUZ, F i-126 ("Qushbegi Fond") O 1 D 1978, f. 20 (detail).

185 Another possible reading here is *sabqat al-aqlām*, 'slips of the pen', but this hardly accords with the context. The number 12 also appears to be written above *sab'a*.

186 Sic.